

CM hails Centre’s decision to regularise unauthorised colonies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Thanking the Centre for the decision to regularise 1,151 unauthorised colonies in the capital, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday termed it a transformative step, adding the decision would bring hope, dignity and long-awaited security to lakhs of families who have lived for years in uncertainty. The Delhi Cabinet, chaired by the Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, also unanimously passed a resolution expressing gratitude to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Union Leadership, including the Urban Development Minister Manohar Lal.

Rekha Gupta said the decision goes beyond legal validation, offering residents a pathway to self-respect, stability and development. She underlined that both the

Centre and the Delhi Government will now work together to take concrete steps towards the comprehensive and planned development of these colonies, ensuring better infrastructure and improved living standards.

She added that the Delhi Government has been sensitive to the concerns of residents in these areas. A lack of basic amenities has long caused hardship, and to address this, ₹800 crore has been earmarked in the 2026-27 budget to strengthen infrastructure. The Centre's decision, she said, has now paved the way for faster development and a tangible improvement in the quality of life of residents.

Under the plan, 1,511 of Delhi's 1,731 unauthorised colonies will be regularised on an "As-is, Where-is" basis. No approval of layout plans will be required, and all plots and



buildings will be treated as residential. Around 4.5 million people are expected to benefit. The entire regularisation process will now be

handled by the Delhi Government's Revenue Department instead of the Delhi Development Authority. A clear timeline has been

DECISIONS TAKEN BY MINISTRY OF HOUSING AND URBAN AFFAIRS

- 1511 unauthorised colonies (out of 1731 UCs), which do not fall under exclusion criteria, will be regularised on an "as-is, where-is" basis without requiring approved layout plans.
- Land use of all plots and buildings in these colonies will be treated as residential.
- Convenience shops up to 20 sq. metres will be regularised if they have access to a right of way of 6 metres. For shops up to 10 sq. metres, the required right of way may be less than 6 metres.
- Regularisation will apply to existing built-up structures on an "as-is where-is" basis.
- Absence of approved layout plans will not be a barrier to regularisation.
- MCD/local bodies will issue Certificates of Regularisation, conduct surveys of vacant plots, and facilitate development of civic infrastructure.
- The Revenue Department, GNCTD, will issue Conveyance Deeds / Authorisation Slips to eligible residents.

laid down for the process from application to the issuance of conveyance deeds. This includes seven days for GIS survey reports, 15 days for

deficiency resolution memos, and a mandatory 45-day deadline for issuing conveyance deeds. The PM-UDAY register will be regularly maintained,

and regularisation certificates will be issued by the MCD. Applications under the scheme will open from April 24, 2026, through the Swagam portal. Highlighting the broader context, the Chief Minister said Delhi's population has nearly doubled over the past two decades — from around 1.5 crore to nearly 3 crore. The city today has thousands of unauthorised colonies, around 675 slum clusters and more than 350 villages, many of which have seen unplanned and unregulated growth over the years.

She said previous governments failed to adequately address the issue, making relocation impractical. The latest decision, she stressed, marks the first significant step towards structured and planned urban development.

She added that her government is continuously working with the Centre to deliver

systematic and well-planned development for Delhi.

Rekha Gupta also emphasised that unauthorised colonies are an integral part of Delhi's urban fabric, and any vision for the Capital's development would remain incomplete without them. The government aims to integrate these colonies into the mainstream of urban development.

However, challenges remain — narrow lanes, houses with limited access points, and high population density make emergency response, especially during fires, extremely difficult.

Keeping this in mind, the government is also working to further strengthen fire services infrastructure to ensure residents' safety. She said the government is approaching the issue not only from a development perspective, but also from the standpoint of safety and urban planning.

MCD to map 1,511 unauthorised colonies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has begun conducting aerial surveys to map and identify unauthorised colonies in Delhi under an integrated framework, which aims to regularise such areas on an "as is where is" basis and grant legal status to its residents.

According to an official statement by MoHUA and the Delhi government, the MCD will now issue Certificates of Regularisation, conduct surveys of vacant plots, and facilitate civic infrastructure development across the 1,511 eligible colonies. According to officials, the MCD has already started aerial surveys and expects to complete them in the next few days.

"At least 151 unauthorised colonies have been mapped via drone surveys and satellite imagery," an official said, adding that remaining colonies will be mapped in



the next 15 days. "Key tools include the MCD-311 app for geotagging and the MCD SWAGAM portal for citizen services. As of April 2026, GIS surveys are being conducted for the regularisation of 1,511+ unauthorised colonies," an official said.

The Delhi government announced that the Revenue Department will continue issuing Conveyance Deeds for properties on government land and authorisation slips for those on private land. According to the official statement, starting April 24, residents who already hold a

Conveyance Deed or authorisation slip can apply through MCD's SWAGAM portal at mcdonline.nic.in/swagam.

The applicant selects their colony, confirms their PM-UDAY case ID, and if documents have been issued, the application proceeds directly. Those without a Case ID are redirected to the PM-UDAY portal first.

The MCD, the Revenue Department of the Government of NCT of Delhi (GNCTD), and the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) have announced a

revamped approach under the PM-UDAY scheme to address a critical gap that left thousands of residents stranded even after receiving their ownership documents.

The absence of layout plans will no longer block regularisation. An inter-agency cell of DDA, MCD, and GNCTD will prepare layout plans using satellite imagery, taking the responsibility away from individual RWAs, the statement read.

As of March 31, only around 40,000 Conveyance Deeds and Authorisation Slips have been issued under PM-UDAY since the scheme's launch, a figure the government itself acknowledges reflects poor uptake.

The reason, officials said, was structural, as residents who received their documents could not get building plans approved because layout plans, which were to be prepared by Resident Welfare Associations and approved by MCD, were never put in place.

MoHUA notifies new TOD policy, charges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) has notified the new Transit Oriented Development (TOD) policy and charges, 2026 for Delhi, which is expected to open up large swathes of land near metro and rapid rail corridors to high-density development, thereby enhancing accessibility and enabling the creation of affordable housing stock.

The current policy has a corridor-based approach and opens up an area of 207 sq. km (500 m on either side of metro corridors and a 500 m radius of RRTS/railway stations, etc.) primarily for the provisioning of affordable housing through planned development and redevelopment. Out of this 207 sq. km, about 80 sq. km of an area under land pooling, low-density residential area and unauthorised colonies, which was excluded in the earlier TOD policy, has now been



brought under the purview of the new TOD policy.

In a joint press conference, Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) Manohar Lal, along with Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, said the TOD concept has already been envisaged in the Master Plan of Delhi 2021 but was delayed due to hurdles — could help address traffic congestion while also supporting the city's housing needs.

He said policy provides flexibility and allows for TOD

development along the operational as well as proposed metro corridors/ RRTS/Railway Stations etc.

This will allow TOD development to commensurate with the construction of the new metro corridors. New affordable housing and related infrastructure can come up in a planned way in such areas. This will also ensure enhanced metro ridership and better livability. The government also notified the Regulations for Transit Oriented Development (TOD) and Charges, 2026.

The citizen(s) requiring to

develop their land shall be required to apply for approvals along with the charges at one point only, without requiring to separately approach any of the service providing agencies such as MCD, DIB, DFS etc. The policy provides for time bound approvals.

"The policy enables the development of smaller-sized plots of 2000 sq.m. under TOD provisions. A maximum FAR of up to 500 is permitted in TOD zones on plots of 2000 sq. m and above, with an 18 m road.

Out of this, 65 per cent of total permissible FAR has been mandatorily earmarked for residential use with dwelling units with a built-up area of 100 sq. m (< 99 sq. m), thereby providing for affordable housing along the metro corridor," he said.

As per the simplified TOD charges, ₹10,000 per sqm will be charged, and the amount collected under a ring-fenced escrow account for development in TOD zones.

ED attaches over ₹39 crore assets of Al-Falah chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Tuesday attached assets worth ₹39.45 crore belonging to Jawad Ahmad Siddiqui, chairman of the Al-Falah Group, and the Al-Falah Charitable Trust.

The provisional order under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) freezes a residential house in Delhi's Jamia Nagar, Okhla area, agricultural land at Dhauj village in Faridabad adjacent to the university campus, Demat holdings, bank balances and fixed deposits.

The action forms part of the first money laundering case registered by the ED against Siddiqui and the trust. The ED has traced ₹493.24 crore in proceeds of crime generated by the Al-Falah Charitable Trust and Al-Falah University between financial years 2016-17 and 2024-25.

Investigators allege these



funds were diverted to entities controlled by Siddiqui and his family, including Karkun Construction and Developers, Amla Enterprises LLP and Diyala Construction and Developers, with some amounts allegedly siphoned abroad. The university first came under the scanner during a probe into a "white-collar" terror module linked to the November 10, 2025, Red Fort car blast in Delhi that killed 15 people.

In January 2026, the ED filed a chargesheet against Siddiqui and the trust. The same month it attached the Al-Falah University campus itself, valued at Rs 144.09 crore.

Siddiqui (61) remains in judicial custody at Tihar Jail. He was first arrested in November 2025 for allegedly cheating students by misrepresenting the accreditation and recognition of his institutions. Last month he was re-arrested in a separate case involving the fraudulent acquisition of a ₹45 crore plot in Delhi.

The latest attachment comes weeks after the Haryana government placed Al-Falah University under direct administrative control in March 2026.

Senior IAS officer Amit K. Aggarwal was appointed administrator following an inquiry that flagged governance lapses, financial irregularities and statutory violations. The move was enabled by the Haryana Private Universities (Amendment) Act, 2025. Teaching staff and operations for the roughly 1,700 students have been kept largely unchanged to ensure continuity.

Rain causes traffic snarls, disruption in flights

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Overcast skies and light rainfall all through Tuesday brought down the mercury in the national Capital, which recorded its coldest April day in three years.

The maximum temperature settled at 28.8 degrees Celsius, several notches below normal. The city had previously seen the maximum temperature drop to 28.4 degrees Celsius on April 1, 2023. The weather office has forecast thunderstorms accompanied by light to moderate rain for Wednesday, with cloudy skies likely to persist.

The downpour led to widespread waterlogging, turning major roads into slow-moving parking lots and impacting operations at Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGI).

Massive snarls were reported across the city. Busy intersections at ITO, Vikas Marg, Arya Samaj Road (Karol Bagh), Dhaura Kuan-Gurgaon



Pedestrians and commuters make their way along a rain-soaked road amid rainfall in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

Road, Delhi Cantt, Palam, Dwarka and routes between Noida and Delhi saw the cascading impact of the rain. Commuters were stuck for hours in many spots, with vehicles crawling through flooded stretches. Social media is full of frustrated

posts about the chaos. No major accidents or casualties have been reported so far, but movement has been severely hampered.

Flight disruptions at Delhi Airport were reported as 15 flights diverted: 8 to Jaipur, 5 to Lucknow, and 2 to

Chandigarh. Airport authorities issued an advisory urging passengers to contact their airlines for the latest updates, as operations were hit.

IndiGo: "Heavy downpour over Delhi... causing some temporary disruption to flight schedules... allow additional time... especially with traffic moving slower than usual." Air India: Downpour "may impact flight operations"; check status and leave early.

Spicejet: Bad weather is affecting all departures/arrivals; monitor flight status. If you're heading to/from the airport tonight, check your airline app or website immediately and add extra buffer time for traffic. Weather is expected to ease later tonight, but thunderstorms could linger.

According to the India Meteorological Department data, between 8:30 am and 5:30 pm, Safdarjung recorded 3.0 mm rainfall, Lodhi Road also logged 3.0 mm, while Palam and Ridge recorded 2.1 mm each.

Ayanagar recorded 2.0 mm of rainfall during the period.

The maximum temperature at Safdarjung was 28.8 degrees Celsius, six notches below normal, while Palam recorded 27.6 degrees Celsius, eight notches below normal. Lodhi Road logged 28.1 degrees Celsius, six notches below normal, Ridge 27.7 degrees Celsius, seven notches below normal, and Ayanagar 27.8 degrees Celsius, seven notches below normal. The minimum temperature at Safdarjung was 20.1 degrees Celsius, close to normal, while Palam recorded 19.6 degrees Celsius, marginally below normal.

Lodhi Road logged 18.6 degrees Celsius, marginally below normal, Ridge 17.2 degrees Celsius, three notches below normal, and Ayanagar 18.1 degrees Celsius, one notch below normal. The minimum temperature on Wednesday is expected to settle at 17 degrees Celsius and the maximum temperature at 28 degrees Celsius.

Over 225 acres of forest land made encroachment-free: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Over 225 acres of forest land in the national capital have been made encroachment-free across multiple forest divisions, according to official data, with the bulk of the clearance reported from the southern parts of the city.

Data compiled by the forest department shows that around 91.15 hectares of land, roughly 225 acres, have been cleared of encroachments since 2019-20, primarily in the South and West forest divisions, while several other areas are still in the process of reconciliation with land-owning agencies.

In the South Forest Division, the highest removal was recorded in the South district, where about 77 hectares or nearly 190 acres of forest land was cleared between 2019-20 and 2024-

25, though a year-wise break-up was not provided.

In the South-East district, about 2.92 hectares or around 7.2 acres was cleared during the same period, with year-wise removal recorded at 0.11 hectares in 2019-20, 1.85 hectares in 2020-21, 0.56 hectares in 2021-22, nil in 2022-23 and 0.4 hectares in 2023-24.

In the West Forest Division, about 11.23 hectares or roughly 27.7 acres of land have been cleared of encroachments between 2019-20 and 2023-24 in parts of the Southern Ridge in the New Delhi district, including areas such as Rajokari, Rangpur, Ghitorni and Mahipalpur.

The year-wise removal stood at 7.67 hectares in 2019-20, 0.4 hectares in 2020-21, 1.57 hectares in 2021-22, 0.7 hectares in 2022-23 and 0.89 hectares in 2023-24, accord-



ing to the data.

The data also indicated that in certain divisions, particularly in areas classified under deemed forests or managed by different agencies, details are being compiled in coordination with the concerned land-owning authorities.

Officials noted that in many divisions, there is "no encroachment" reported on forest land under the direct

control of the forest department, while information regarding other areas is being updated in consultation with relevant agencies.

The data further showed that action taken has included the issuance of notices, demarcation exercises and communication with revenue authorities and other departments for the removal of unauthorised structures.

THE FIGURES COME AMID ONGOING MONITORING OF FOREST CONSERVATION AND EFFORTS TO REMOVE ENCROACHMENTS IN THE CAPITAL

The figures come amid ongoing monitoring of forest conservation and efforts to remove encroachments in the national capital.

Meanwhile, according to a communication issued by the regional office of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, encroachments on forest land are to be removed within two years from the date of issuance of the letter in November last year, with a compliance report to be submitted thereafter.

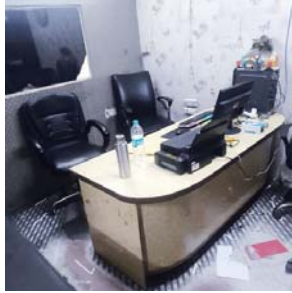
Fake call centre busted, 12 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has busted a fake call centre operating in central Delhi's Guru Arjun Nagar and apprehended 12 people, including two proprietors, for allegedly cheating customers by selling fraudulent roadside assistance policies.

The operation was carried out by the Anti-Narcotics Cell of the Central District following specific intelligence inputs. The accused were running the call centre under the name "RD Services" and had been targeting customers across the country. Deputy Commissioner of Police, Central District, Rohit Rajbir Singh, said the racket was unearthed after credible information was received about the illegal operation.

"The accused were running a fake call centre



and cheating people by selling roadside assistance policies without providing any actual service," he said. He added that a case has been registered and further investigation is underway.

Police said the raid was conducted on April 4 at Rattan Lal Complex in Guru Arjun Nagar under the jurisdiction of the Ranjeet Nagar police station.

A police team carried out the operation and found the call centre functioning with multiple telecallers actively

making calls to potential victims. Among those apprehended are the two proprietors, identified as Sourabh and Shah Nawaz, both aged 28 years. Ten telecallers, including men and women in their early twenties, were also detained from the premises.

During the investigation, police found that the accused used to contact customers through random calls as well as targeted data.

They offered roadside assistance services for vehicles, claiming that help would be provided anywhere in India in case of breakdowns, tyre punctures, or emergencies.

To gain the trust of customers, the accused offered cash on delivery as a payment option. Victims were told that they would receive a plastic policy card and could make payment upon delivery. The charges ranged between ₹3,000 and ₹4,000 per policy.

IN FOCUS



Farmers carrying a crate of vegetable on a bicycle after washing the same in the Ganga river during sunrise in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh

Yogi launches 325 projects worth ₹6,466 crore in Agra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow/Agra

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Tuesday inaugurated and laid the foundation stones for 325 development projects worth ₹6,466.37 crore in Agra and announced plans to develop a 'Greater Agra' township, officials said.

The chief minister said the proposed township would emerge as a major urban and economic hub, according to an official statement issued in Lucknow. "Greater Agra will become the second Noida, opening new avenues of employment and attracting big companies," Adityanath said. According to the statement,



CM Yogi Adityanath during the Malook Jayanti Mahotsav, at Shree Malook Peeth Ashram (Vanshivat) in Vrindavan

PTI

the township would be developed by the Agra Development Authority under the state's 'New City Promotion Scheme' at an estimated cost of around Rs 5,142 crore over 449.65 hectares in Raipur and

Rahankalan areas.

It said the project has received RERA approval and would provide multi-storey flats, group housing, plots, modern roads, sewerage systems, green spaces and other civic amenities for

over 10,000 families. The sectors of the township will be named after 10 sacred rivers, including Ganga, Yamuna and Saraswati.

Adityanath said the Government aims to transform Agra from a tourism-centric city into a modern cultural and economic centre, the statement added.

Referring to public participation, he expressed gratitude for the support extended by the people of Agra and said the Government has delivered major infrastructure projects, including the Agra Metro. The chief minister said the development of Agra airport would be expedited, and a new civil terminal is expected by the end of this year.

58 cops injured in clash with tribals in Odisha

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhubaneswar



At least 70 people, including 58 security personnel, were injured on Tuesday in a clash with local tribals over the construction of a road to the Sijimali bauxite mine in Odisha's Rayagada district, officials said.

The tribals, who have been strongly opposing the road project at Shagabari village under Kashipur block of the district, allegedly attacked the police personnel and district administration officials with swords, axes, and stones. ADG (Law and Order) Sanjay Kumar said the injured police personnel were admitted to different hospitals in Rayagada and Visakhapatnam. He said some women personnel were also injured in the indiscriminate stone pelting by the

mob. Rayagada SP Swathy S Kumar said a mob of around 250 villagers rounded up police personnel when they had gone to Kantamal village within Kashipur police station area to arrest a person wanted in 14 criminal cases.

Sources said the accused person was one of the tribal leaders who opposed the road construction to Sijimali mines. "Our personnel, including policewomen, were encircled and pelted with stones. In self-defence, we lobbed tear gas shells to disperse the mob and evacuated the injured," Kumar said.

Security reviewed at Vaishno Devi shrine

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jammu

Authorities on Tuesday conducted a comprehensive security review at the Mata Vaishno Devi shrine in Jammu and Kashmir's Reasi district and directed for maintaining a high level of alertness for smooth pilgrimage, police said.

Peripheral security arrangements around the shrine and adjoining areas were thoroughly evaluated to ensure a robust multi-layered

security grid, a police spokesperson said. After assuming charge as Deputy Inspector General of Police, Udhampur-Reasi Range, Shiv Kumar Sharma visited Katra — the base camp for the pilgrims visiting the shrine atop Trikuta hills — to review security arrangements on the ground, particularly along the track leading to Bhawan.

The spokesperson said inspections were carried out at CRPF camps, joint Check Points, and security pickets established along the route.

5-kg LPG cylinder quota doubled to ease supply concerns: Joint Secretary

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government has doubled the daily quota of market-priced 5-kg LPG cylinders for migrant workers as part of a broader push to stabilise fuel supplies amid disruptions linked to tensions around the Strait of Hormuz.

Unlike the subsidised 14.2-kg cylinders that are used in household kitchens for cooking, the 5-kg bottles are priced at market rates. A 5-kg cylinder costs Rs 549 in Delhi as against the Rs 913 price for a 14.2-kg domestic cylinder.

The 5-kg cylinders are available across-the-counter at LPG distributorships on production of a simple



identity card (no address proof needed). Regular domestic connections are given after a complete KYC. With the war in West Asia disrupting energy supplies, the Government has prioritised cooking gas supply to households as the cost of commercial users, who were initially given only 20 per cent of their requirement and in steps raised to 70 per cent. Migrant workers mostly do not have regular cooking gas connections. To ease their burden, the Government has now made available higher numbers of 5-kg cylinders.

At a news briefing, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said the Government vide

letter dated April 6 has conveyed that daily quantity of 5 kg free trade LPG (FTL) cylinders in each state available for disbursal to migrant labourers is being doubled based on the average daily supply (number of such cylinders) during March 2-3.

She said in February, 77,000 kg FTL cylinders were sold and the sale on March 2-3 was higher than that. Since March 23, about 7.8 lakh 5-kg FTL cylinders have been sold, she said, adding that on Monday more than 1.06 lakh 5-kg FTL cylinders were sold across the country.

The Government has also increased commercial LPG allocation to about 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels and stepped up

enforcement, with over 4,300 raids conducted to curb hoarding and black marketing.

She urged citizens to avoid panic buying of petrol, diesel, and LPG, stressing that adequate stocks are available and retail outlets are operating normally.

Supplies of LPG and piped natural gas (PNG) have been prioritised for households and critical sectors such as hospitals, while refinery output has been ramped up and alternative fuels promoted.

Natural gas supplies to priority segments, including domestic piped natural gas (PNG) and transport CNG, remain fully protected, with additional allocations to fertiliser and industrial sectors.

Fresh violence in Manipur; four dead...

Locals alleged the attack was carried out by suspected Kuki insurgents. Meanwhile, the Kuki-Zo Council condemned the incident and rejected the allegations levelled by the locals and described it as a tragic attack on innocents.

As the information about the tragic death of children spread, locals gathered in large numbers to protest in Bishnupur. They blocked roads, burned tyres and set fire to at least three trucks near a petrol pump in Moirang area.

The situation took an unpleasant turn when some demonstrators, who had gathered at the Moirang police station, tried to storm a CRPF camp in the area. Eyewitnesses reported damage to camp premises as the mob grew agitated and attempted to break through the security cordon.

Security forces including CRPF personnel firsts lobbed used tear shells to disperse the mob. They subsequently opened fire as the mob refused to budge. Two civilians died on the spot in the firing while, several others were injured. They were rushed to Government hospital in Imphal for treatment.

As the situation deteriorated, the State home department ordered the temporary suspension of internet in five valley districts; Imphal East, Imphal West, Thoubal, Kakching and Bishnupur for three days, effective from 2:00 pm on April 7, 2026. The step was taken to prevent rumour mongering and misuse of social media platforms for stoking emotion in the sensitive border states, an official said.

Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh visited the injured mother at the hospital. He described the attack as a barbaric act and an assault on humanity, calling it a deliberate attempt to disturb the state's fragile peace. He assured that those responsible would be identified and dealt with strictly under the law.

Tensions remain high in the affected areas but no major fresh incidents have been reported beyond the initial violence. Security forces have been deployed in strength, and normal life is disrupted in parts of the valley districts due to the protests and internet shutdown.

Campaigning ends in Kerala, Assam...

The opposition Congress and its alliance partners have accused the BJP of practising the 'politics of hate', indulging in widespread corruption, particularly by the CM and his family members, lopsided development, and not being serious about ensuring justice to popular singer Zubeen Garg, who died in Singapore on September 19 last year. CM chief minister accused state Congress president Gaurav Gogoi and his wife of having links with Pakistan's spy agency ISI. On the other hand, the opposition party charged Sarma's wife Riniki Bhuyan Sharma with owning multiple passports, properties in Dubai and assets in shell companies, which her husband did not mention in his poll affidavit.

In a final show of strength as campaign ended in Kerala, workers from all parties converged at designated centres. The contest is mainly among three fronts in the polls — the CPI(M)-led LDF, the Congress-led UDF and the BJP-led NDA. During the nearly month-long campaign, top leaders flew in repeatedly from New Delhi — including Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah for the NDA, alongside Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra for the UDF — while Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan led from the front for the ruling LDF.

Congress tried to build a narrative of an alleged understanding between the BJP and the CPI(M), while also accusing the LDF of having links with

the SDPI. It raised issues of corruption and governance against the state Government.

The BJP, on its part, focused on attacking both the LDF and the UDF. It argued that Kerala had not seen meaningful development under either front and presented itself as an alternative. PM Modi and other central leaders campaigned extensively, especially after the party's improved performance in recent local body elections, including winning the Thiruvananthapuram Corporation.

Several key issues dominated the campaign. The Sabarimala temple row returned to the spotlight after the Supreme Court sought the state's stand on women's entry.

Campaigning for the April 9 elections to the Assembly of the Puducherry Union territory ended as political parties, independent candidates and rebel candidates of political parties were in a last-ditch attempt to impress voters. Puducherry, Karaikal, Mahe and Yanam regions of the Union Territory (UT) together have thirty seats in the Assembly. A total of 294 candidates are in the fray. The upcoming poll is a prestige fight for the NDA and INDIA bloc.

Trump warns of 'end of a civilisation'

The attack marked the second time the island was hit by American forces.

Trump has extended previous deadlines but suggested the one set for 8 pm in Washington was final, and the rhetoric on both sides reached a fever pitch, leaving Iranians on edge.

Trump threatened to destroy all of Iran's power plants and bridges if Tehran does not allow traffic to fully resume in the strait, through which a fifth of the world's oil transits in peacetime. Iran's president said 14 million people, including himself, have volunteered to fight.

It was not clear if the latest airstrikes were linked to Trump's threat to attack bridges. At least two of the targets were connected to Iran's rail network. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israeli warplanes struck bridges and railways in Iran. In a statement released by his office, Netanyahu claimed Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard was using them to transport materials to make weapons. Israel had earlier issued a Farsi-language warning telling Iranians to avoid trains throughout the day.

Iran, meanwhile, fired on Israel and Saudi Arabia, prompting the temporary closure of a major bridge.

While Iran cannot match the sophistication of US and Israeli weaponry or their dominance in the air, its chokehold on the strait is roiling the world economy and raising the pressure on Trump both at home and abroad to find a way out of the standoff.

Officials involved in diplomatic efforts said talks were ongoing, but Iran has rejected the latest American proposal, and it was unclear if a deal would come in time to head off Trump's threatened attacks. World leaders and experts warned that strikes as destructive as Trump threatened could constitute a war crime.

"A whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again," if a deal isn't reached, Trump said in a post Tuesday morning, while keeping open the possibility of an off-ramp, saying that "maybe something revolutionarily wonderful can happen."

Earlier, Iranian official Alireza Rahimi issued a video message calling on "all young people, athletes, artists, students and university students and their professors" to form human chains around power plants.

Iranians have formed human chains in the past around nuclear sites at times of heightened tensions with the West. Some images of people surrounding power plants were posted by local

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Iranian media Tuesday, though it was unclear how widespread the practice was or if the photos were simply brief shows of Government-encouraged defiance.

President Masoud Pezeshkian posted on X that 14 million Iranians had answered campaigns urging people to volunteer to fight - and said he would join them - while a Revolutionary Guard general urged parents to send their children to man checkpoints. The Guard, meanwhile, warned that Iran would "deprive the US and its allies of the region's oil and gas for years" and expand its attacks across the Gulf region if Trump carries out his threat.

In Tehran, the mood was bleak. A young teacher said that many opponents of Iran's Islamic system had hoped Trump's attacks would quickly topple it. Now, as the war drags on, she fears US and Israeli strikes will spread chaos. "If we don't have the internet, and if we don't have electricity, water, and gas, we're really going back to the Stone Age, as Trump said," she told The Associated Press, speaking anonymously for her safety. French Foreign Minister Jean-Noel Barrot joined a growing chorus of international voices and calling for restraint, saying attacks targeting civilian and energy infrastructure "are barred by the rules of war, international law."

"They would without doubt trigger a new phase of escalation, of reprisals, that would drag the region and the world economy into a vicious circle," the minister said on France Info television. UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres also warned the US that attacks on civilian infrastructure are banned under international law, according to his spokesperson.

Such cases are notoriously difficult to prosecute, and Trump told reporters he's "not at all" concerned about committing war crimes.

Khamenei unconscious, says report

Iran has acknowledged that Khamenei was wounded in an airstrike on February 28 that killed his father, Ali Khamenei, along with several close family members. Officials maintain that the supreme leader remains "in charge" of the country, despite his absence from public view since the outbreak of the war. No verified video or audio of him has emerged; only written statements read on state television and a recently released AI-generated clip have been circulated.

The lack of direct communication has fueled speculation that Khamenei may be incapacitated. Opposition groups allege he is in a coma, while other unverified reports suggest serious injuries, including fractures and facial wounds. The uncertainty has intensified questions about Iran's chain of command, where the supreme leader traditionally holds ultimate political and religious authority.

The situation has also sparked debate over the role of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), with some observers suggesting the military may be running day-to-day operations, potentially reducing Khamenei to a symbolic figurehead. US President Donald Trump appeared to reinforce this perception, stating that negotiations were ongoing with other Iranian officials rather than the supreme leader himself.

Meanwhile, preparations are reportedly underway in Qom for the burial of Ali Khamenei. Intelligence indicates plans for a large mausoleum capable of holding multiple graves. The delay in his funeral, unusual in Shia tradition which mandates swift burial, has added to speculation, particularly as Wednesday marks 40 days since his death-the formal end of the mourning period. The unfolding developments in Qom underscore growing uncertainty within Iran's leadership at a critical time, as the country navigates both internal instability and an escalating international crisis.

Property registration eased for unauthorised...

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, and senior officials of Delhi Development Authority (DDA), MoHUA and Delhi Government were also present at the press conference.

Further, the revenue department of the Delhi Government will now issue conveyance deeds for ownership rights instead of the DDA. This means the Delhi Government will now issue ownership deeds. The Government has also simplified the process for applying for ownership rights under the PM-UDAY (Pradhan Mantri — Unauthorised Colonies in Delhi Awas Adhikar Yojana) scheme. Applications open online from April 24, benefiting nearly 50 lakh residents. However, 69 unauthorised colonies including Sainik Farms, Mahendur Enclave and Anantram Dairy, were not given the relief.

Colonies falling under exclusions — where no rights are to be conferred — include those located on prohibited land such as reserved, notified forests, areas protected under the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958, Zone-O (Yamuna Flood Plain), right of way of roads, high tension lines, ridge areas of Delhi, or land protected under any law.

A structured timeline for effect the policy change has been put in place — GIS survey within seven days, rectification of application deficiencies within 15 days, and issuance of conveyance deeds within 45 days. As per the revised policy, land use of all plots and buildings in these colonies will be treated as residential. Convenience shops up to 20 sq metres will be regularised if they have access to a right of way of six metres. For shops up to 10 sq metres, the required right of way may be less than six metres.

Announcing the revised policy Khattar clarified that while the revised "as is where is" policy covers existing structures in unauthorised colonies, any new construction will still need to adhere to norms set by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi and obtain necessary approvals.

91 lakh voters deleted in West Bengal

The process of adding e-signatures by judicial officers remains pending in over 22,000 cases, leaving room for further deletions.

More than 32.68 lakh of those in the 'under adjudication' category have been retained and included in the final rolls. The final deletions, since the beginning of the SIR process, were around 90.83 lakh, according to the EC data.

Before the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in West Bengal on November 4 last year, the total number of voters in the state stood at 7.66 crore when the electoral list was frozen on October 27. In the draft voters' list published in December last year, a total of 58,20,899 names were deleted. In the final voters' list published on February 28, the deletion figure rose to 63,66,952.

A Trinamool Congress delegation will meet the poll body on Wednesday and raise the issue of people being "disenfranchised" due to the SIR in West Bengal. Meanwhile, with the publication of the final supplementary list, the electoral roll for the first phase of West Bengal assembly elections has been "frozen" after midnight on Monday in accordance with prescribed norms, he said.

Of the 294 seats in the assembly, 152 seats will go to the polls on April 23 in the first phase, and the remaining 142 seats will vote in the second phase on April 29. The rolls for the second round will be frozen on April 9.

Meanwhile, the poll body may roll out the third and final phase of special intensive revision of voters' list in the remaining 22 states and Union

territories, including Delhi, after the polls to five assemblies this month. The officials said special intensive revision (SIR) could be rolled out after the polls conclude on April 29. Another possibility is to begin the massive exercise after the declaration of results.

Khera 'missing' after Assam Police raid

The case is based on a complaint filed by the CM's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma. The case has been registered at the Crime Branch Police Station in Guwahati, the DCP said.

He added that electronic devices were seized during the search, stating that some "incriminating material" was found at Khera's residence, without providing further details. Khera had alleged the CM's wife held three foreign passports from the UAE, Egypt, and Antigua and Barbuda, and also questioned property links in Dubai and assets connected to companies in the US.

Riniki Bhuyan Sarma has categorically denied the claims, calling the documents fake. "It seems that a mad dog has bitten them. From the top rung of the Congress to the lowest rung, I believe that they don't have anything else to do except defaming people, that too with AI-generated and total photoshop," she told mediapersons on Monday.

Himanta Biswa Sarma backed up her denial with a technical counter-argument. He said his team conducted a reverse Google search on the ID number of the alleged UAE document and found that the original belonged to an Egyptian national, whose image had been shared on a Pakistani Facebook group as a lost document.

Sarma further said that a separate verification of the machine-readable zone code on another document indicated that it belonged to a different individual altogether. He also pointed out discrepancies such as mismatched birth years and incorrect listing of place of birth in the purported passport documents.

The Assam CM added that the Union Government sought clarification from the three countries in relation to the documents, and all of them indicated that the documents were not genuine. After reports of the police search surfaced, Sarma claimed that Khera had left Guwahati and was not in Delhi. He said he had learned through media reports that Khera was currently in Hyderabad. "The law will take its own course," Sarma said.

The Congress party strongly criticised the police action. Leaders termed the search politically motivated and accused the Assam Government of misusing state machinery. A Congress leader close to Khera said that the allegations raised by him should be investigated instead of initiating police action. The leader also confirmed that Khera was not in Delhi at the time of the search. Congress Rajya Sabha MP Jairam Ramesh also reacted sharply, alleging that the move was an attempt to silence the Opposition. He said the deployment of police against Khera for raising questions in the public interest showed desperation on the part of the Assam Chief Minister.

Ramesh described the action as a "witch hunt" and accused the Government of using intimidation tactics. He further alleged that such steps reflected fear and an attempt to suppress dissent. Police officials said the investigation is ongoing and further steps will be taken based on evidence collected during the probe. Efforts are expected to be made to question Khera as part of the investigation. The case has triggered a political confrontation between the ruling side in Assam and the Congress, with both sides standing firm on their positions as the probe continues.

West Asia crisis disrupts Indian aviation, 10,000 flights cancelled

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The ongoing conflict in West Asia has severely disrupted India's aviation sector, leading to the cancellation of more than 10,000 flights since late February, a senior Government official said on Tuesday. Escalating tensions and widespread airspace restrictions across the region have significantly impacted international flight operations, particularly long-haul routes to Europe and North America.

According to Asangba Chuba Ao, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Civil Aviation, Indian carriers that previously operated 300-350 daily flights to the Middle East have seen that number drop sharply to around 80-90. The decline follows the closure or restriction of airspace in several West Asian countries, including Israel, Jordan, Lebanon, Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain, and the UAE.

The conflict, triggered by



military action involving the United States, Israel, and Iran, has caused what officials describe as "unprecedented disruption in global aviation networks." Airlines have been forced to reroute flights, increasing travel time and operational costs.

To mitigate the impact, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has temporarily relaxed Flight Duty Time Limitations (FDTL), allowing pilots to

operate longer hours. This includes extending permissible flight time to approximately 11.5 hours to accommodate extended flight paths. The relaxation is currently valid until April 30 and may be reviewed depending on how the situation evolves.

Officials also highlighted rising aviation turbine fuel (ATF) costs as a major challenge, noting that fuel accounts for nearly 40 per cent of airline operating

expenses. While global fuel prices have surged, the Government has moderated domestic price increases to prevent a steep rise in airfares.

Additional measures include allowing foreign airlines such as Emirates, Kuwait Airways, and Jazeera Airways to operate passenger aircraft for cargo services, ensuring continuity in critical supply chains.

Despite the Government's efforts, the crisis has placed financial strain on airlines. Around 50 per cent of Indian carriers' international operations are linked to West Asia, making the disruption particularly significant. Airlines have begun introducing distance-based surcharges to offset rising fuel costs.

The Ministry of Civil Aviation stated it is working closely with stakeholders to support the sector and maintain stability. "Passenger safety, cargo continuity, and sectoral resilience remain our top priorities," the official said.

Himachal court summons Sisodia in defamation case



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Una (HP)

A court in Himachal Pradesh's Una district on Tuesday issued summons to AAP leader Manish Sisodia in connection with an alleged defamation case filed by a former State president of the party and directed him to appear before it on May 12.

The case was filed by Anoop Kesari, a lawyer from Una, who along with his supporters quit the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and joined the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in 2022.

Kesari, who was then the president of AAP's Himachal unit, has alleged in his com-

plaint that after he left the party, Sisodia, out of frustration, held a press conference in Delhi on April 9, 2022 and levelled serious allegations against him.

According to Kesari, no evidence or proof was presented to substantiate these allegations.

Feeling aggrieved by "this act of character assassination carried out from a public platform without any supporting evidence", Kesari approached the Una court.

After examining the petitioner's arguments and evidence, the court issued summons to the former deputy chief minister of Delhi and directed him to appear on May 12.

CM Sai presents Bastar 2.0 development blueprint to PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Tuesday presented Prime Minister Narendra Modi with a "forward-looking vision" for the next phase of development in Bastar, one of the regions worst affected by Naxal violence and now moving towards peace.

According to a release issued by the State Government, the chief minister expressed gratitude for the restoration of peace in the region following the decline of Naxalism and credited the

continued support and leadership of the PM for it.

Highlighting the region's potential, the vision document outlines a transformative roadmap designed to accelerate economic progress and improve the quality of life. In addition, the CM invited the PM to visit Bastar after the monsoon season, the release said.

The proposed visit is expected to serve as a significant milestone, with plans for laying the foundation stones of several major projects and inaugurating key initiatives in his presence, signalling the beginning of a new era of



Prime Minister Narendra Modi presented a memento to Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai during a meeting in New Delhi

growth for the region, it said. The CM said the development blueprint for Bastar is built around the core strategy of

'Saturate, Connect, Facilitate, Empower, and Engage' and this approach aims to ensure rapid and inclusive expansion

of basic infrastructure and essential services across the region.

A key focus is on integrating remote and previously isolated villages into the mainstream through a robust road network, alongside the completion of pending works under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana by 2027.

It includes the construction of 228 new roads and 267 bridges. In addition, proposals for 61 new projects have been submitted, seeking special central assistance to further accelerate development, the State Government release said.

Sai emphasised that Naxalism has been eliminated across Chhattisgarh, including Bastar, paving the way for lasting peace in the region. He highlighted major strides in education and healthcare, including the development of new education cities, super-specialty hospitals, and medical colleges. Connectivity is also being significantly strengthened through key infrastructure projects such as the construction of barrages on the Indravati River, expansion of railway networks and development of airport facilities, the chief minister noted.

NSA Doval hosts Bangladesh Foreign Minister



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval hosted Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman for a dinner meeting on Tuesday, hours after the latter landed in New Delhi for a three-day visit aimed at repairing bilateral ties following more than 18 months of heightened diplomatic tension. It is the first high-level visit to India by a senior member of the new Bangladesh Nationalist Party Government led by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman that came to power in February following the parliamentary elections.

Various aspects of India-Bangladesh relations figured in the talks between Doval and Rahman with a focus on charting a new momentum in the ties, people familiar with the matter said. There is no official word on the meeting yet.

Foreign Minister Rahman's delegation included Humayun Kabir, foreign affairs adviser to the prime minister. Rahman is scheduled to hold extensive talks with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Wednesday. The Bangladesh foreign minister will also meet Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri.

Warm welcome to Foreign Minister Rahman of Bangladesh on his arrival in New Delhi today, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on social media.

India and Bangladesh share warm and historic ties anchored in strong people to people relations, he said, adding Rahman's visit will "further bolster" India Bangladesh partnership.

God knows how many parts Pak will split into: Rajnath on Kolkata threat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Barrackpore (Bengal)

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Tuesday hit back at Pakistan Defence Minister Khawaja Asif's recent remarks related to striking Kolkata and said only "the god would know how many parts Pakistan would be divided if they cast an eye on Bengal."

He also cautioned Asif to refrain from giving such a "provocative statement" as Pakistan faced the consequences when it was divided into two parts. Rajnath made these assertions in a rally in poll-bound Bengal.

"Fifty-five years ago, they suffered the consequences when Pakistan was divided into two parts. If they try to cast an eye on Bengal, only god knows how many parts Pakistan will be divided into this time," he said.

This sharp reaction came after Asif last week said



Rajnath Singh addressing a public meeting at Barrackpore in North 24 Parganas district on Tuesday

Islamabad would retaliate by striking Kolkata in the event of any future misadventure by India.

The Pakistan defence minister made these remarks after Rajnath Singh last week warned that any "misadventure" would invite "unprecedented and decisive retaliation."

He had also talked about a decisive action in the event of any "misadventure"

carried out by India's neighbour amid the current global situation due to the Iran war. However, Rajnath did not name Pakistan.

"Our neighbour, in the current situation, can commit any misadventure. If it does so, India's action will be unprecedented and decisive, the defence minister had said adding that Operation Sindoor is not over yet.

Below-normal monsoon for India in 2026: Skymet

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Even as many parts of India are enjoying pleasant weather due to the rains, the forecast for the next few months is not encouraging. Skymet, a private weather forecast agency, has predicted a below-normal monsoon in view of El Niño emerging later this year.

This probable scenario is negative for groundwater and reservoirs' recharge and the power situation. Moreover, the forecast comes amid the ongoing geopolitical chaos, rising crude prices and inflation. It means India will have to shore up its food stocks as agriculture is based on rain-fed water.

Skymet, which has come out with its prediction of the South-West Monsoon at least 10 days ahead of the India Meteorological Department, expects the monsoon to be 94 per cent (with an error margin of +/- 5 per cent) of the long-period average (LPA)

ON A MONTHLY SCALE, THE PRECIPITATION FORESHADOW IS AS FOLLOW

- | | |
|---|--|
| ● June – 101% of LPA (LPA for June = 165.3mm) | ● for August = 254.9mm) |
| ● 70% chance of normal | ● 20% chance of normal |
| ● 10% chance of above normal | ● 20% chance of above normal |
| ● 20% chance of below normal | ● 60% chance of below normal |
| ● July – 95% of LPA (LPA for July = 280.5mm) | ● September – 89% of LPA (LPA for September = 167.9mm) |
| ● 40% chance of normal | ● 20% chance of normal |
| ● 20% chance of above normal | ● 10% chance of above normal |
| ● 40% chance of below normal | ● 70% chance of below normal |
| ● August – 92% of LPA (LPA | |

of 868.6 mm for the 4-month-long period from June to September. The spread is below normal, being 90-95 per cent of LPA.

In its earlier forecast in Jan 2026, Skymet assessed the Monsoon 2026 to be subpart and now retains the same. In terms of Geographical prospects, Skymet expects the core Monsoon rain fed zone of the central and

western parts to witness inadequate rainfall.

Punjab, Haryana, and Rajasthan are likely to observe less than normal rains, and more so, during August-September. The eastern and northeastern parts will be placed better than the rest of the country.

According to Jatin Singh, Managing Director, Skymet, "After a year and a half of La

J&K Police bust inter-State LeT module; 5 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Police claimed to have busted an inter-State module of the Pakistan-based terror outfit Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) in Srinagar, arresting five individuals, including two Pakistani terrorists.

Among the prize catch, the Jammu and Kashmir Police successfully nabbed Abdullah alias Abu Hureira, a key operative who had allegedly evaded security agencies for nearly 16 years, and another Pakistani terrorist identified as Usman alias Khubaib.

At least three other Srinagar residents identified as Mohammad Nageeb Bhat, Adil Rashid Bhat and Ghulam Mohammad Mir have also been taken into custody for allegedly providing logistical support, including shelter and food, to the LeT operatives in the valley.

Preliminary investigations suggest that the



(L-R): LeT terrorists Abdullah alias Abu Hureira and Usman alias Khubaib



module was involved in facilitating movement, logistics and possibly financial channels for foreign terrorists.

The police authorities launched the secret operation after receiving credible intelligence about the presence of LeT operatives. It is learnt that these LeT terror-

ists were tracked based on their digital footprints. Senior police authorities have not ruled out the involvement of a few other active operatives in the terror network and have expanded the scope of operations beyond Jammu and Kashmir.

To crush down the terror

Nation Focus



PM CONGRATULATES VIETNAM'S NEW PRESIDENT TO LAM

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday congratulated To Lam on his election as the president of Vietnam and said he was confident that under his leadership, the time-tested friendship between the two countries would continue to grow from strength to strength. Modi also said that he was looking forward to working closely together to further deepen the India-Vietnam Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for the progress and prosperity of the people of the two countries and the region. "Heartiest congratulations to To Lam on his election as President of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam. I am confident that under his leadership, the time-tested friendship between our two countries will continue to grow from strength to strength," he said in a post on social media. Vietnam unanimously elected Communist Party General Secretary To Lam as president for a five-year term, consolidating his control over both the party and the State.



11 IAS OFFICERS TRANSFERRED IN MAHARASHTRA

The Maharashtra Government on Tuesday transferred 11 Indian Administrative Service officers. As per the Government order, Rahul Ranjan Mahiwal has been appointed as Member Secretary of the Maharashtra Council of Agricultural Education and Research in Pune. He was serving as Managing Director of the Maharashtra State Farming Corporation. Shweta Singhal was posted as Special Resident Commissioner at Maharashtra Sadan in New Delhi, while Ruchesh Jaivanshi was appointed Managing Director of the Maharashtra State Farming Corporation in Pune. Kanhuraj Bagate was posted as Joint Managing Director of MAHADISCOM in Kalyan. Laxman Raut has been appointed Chief Executive Officer of the Maharashtra State Khadi and Village Industries Board in Mumbai.

CBI examines ex-finance secretary in currency thread irregularities case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Tuesday questioned former finance secretary Arvind Mayaram in connection with an FIR against him and a UK-based company for alleged corruption in the supply of exclusive colour shift security thread for Indian bank notes, officials said. Mayaram was called to the agency headquarters through a notice, which was received by him on Sunday, they said.

He was questioned during the day by a team of officials from the Anti-Corruption unit of the agency, the officials said.

The CBI officers recorded his statement and also sought his response on several documents, they said. The CBI, in its FIR registered in 2023, had alleged that Mayaram, the UK-based company De La Rue



Former finance secretary Arvind Mayaram

International Ltd and unidentified officials of the finance ministry and RBI hatched a criminal conspiracy to extend undue favour to the firm.

Mayaram was Secretary, Department of Economic Affairs, in the Union Finance Ministry from April 2012 to August 2014 and Finance Secretary from August 2014 to October 2014.

The agency alleged that Mayaram, as the finance sec-

retary, granted an "illegal" three-year extension to an "expired contract" with the UK based company De La Rue for supplying exclusive colour shift security thread without taking any mandatory security clearance from the Home Ministry or informing the then Finance Minister, they said. The extension granted by Mayaram was allegedly the fourth, the FIR said. Earlier CBI searched Mayaram's home in Jaipur.

■ States Focus ■



LAW MUST RESPECT FAITH: THAROOR ON SABARIMALA CASE

Congress leader Shashi Tharoor on Tuesday said those interpreting the law must take faith into account, arguing that one has to understand and respect the faith of people. Speaking to the media, the Thiruvananthapuram MP highlighted the Sabarimala women's entry issue and the lessons learned from the controversy.

He said he had written in detail about the matter earlier and urged people to read his views.

Referring to the controversy over the entry of women of menstruating age into the Sabarimala Temple, Tharoor said the Left Government in Kerala had realised its mistake.

"One of the very important lessons that the LDF Government has learned... is that you cannot just act blindly, without regard to the particularities of the wishes of the people and the faith of the people," he said.



VIJAYAN, REVANTH TRADE BARBS AS CAMPAIGNING ENDS

A war of words between Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and his Telangana counterpart Revanth Reddy turned acrimonious on Tuesday, the final day of campaigning for the April 9 Assembly polls.

The escalation came after Vijayan, responding to Reddy's earlier remarks, used Malayalam expressions considered nearly derogatory, signalling strong disapproval of the Telangana CM's comments.

Reddy, who was campaigning for the UDF in Pathanapuram in Kollam district, hit back swiftly, likening Vijayan to Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

He said he would take any personal remarks from the senior leader as a "blessing" considering his age, but objected to what he described as insults directed at the people of Kerala. "But you cannot abuse our Kerala people," he said, hours before campaigning drew to a close. The controversy began after Reddy had used the words "nee po mone Vijaya" in invoking a famous dialogue from superstar Mohanlal's blockbuster movie "Narasimham" while referring to Vijayan on April 1 during a UDF campaign roadshow in Nemom constituency.

Matua, minorities targeted in voter deletions: Mamata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chakdaha/Bongaon

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday alleged that names of people belonging to the Matua and minority communities were deleted from the post-SIR voter rolls in the State.

Addressing a rally at Chakdaha in Nadia district, Banerjee said that the TMC will stand by those whose names were excluded from the voter rolls, following the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise.

According to the latest Election Commission data, nearly 91 lakh voters have been deleted from the electoral rolls in West Bengal after the SIR process.

The poll panel is yet to announce the finally altered voter base for the State after the roll revision process.

As per official data released on February 28, 63.66 lakh names, around 8.3 per cent of the electorate, were deleted since the SIR process began in



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee addresses a public rally in support of TMC candidate for Chakdaha constituency Subhankar Singha, unseen, ahead of State Assembly elections in Nadia district on Tuesday PTI

November last year, reducing the voter base from about 7.66 crore to just over 7.04 crore.

Accusing the Centre of discrimination, Banerjee alleged that names were being removed from voter rolls by targeting specific communities. "Why this discrimination? You are excluding Matuas, Rajbanshis and minorities. Do you think that people do not understand this?" the CM said.

She also claimed that in districts with significant

minority population such as Murshidabad, Malda and North Dinajpur, names were "picked and removed like lice" from the electoral rolls.

Banerjee asserted that following her intervention in the Supreme Court, around 32 lakh names out of nearly 60 lakh cases under 'adjudication' had been restored.

"Those whose names are still missing should apply before the tribunal. The TMC will stand by you and provide legal support," she said.

BJP slams Kharge over 'illiterate' remark, seeks apology

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Tuesday demanded an apology from Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge for his alleged remarks about the people of Gujarat and some other States, saying that the comment was "shameless, demeaning and utterly despicable."

The ruling party also condemned Kharge's alleged remarks comparing the RSS and the BJP to "poisonous snakes," terming them "deeply objectionable" and beyond the limits of acceptable political discourse.

Addressing a press conference, BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad asked Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi, Sonia Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra to clarify whether they agreed with Kharge's statement.

At an election rally in Kerala's Idukki district on Sunday, Kharge said the people of the State were "educated and clever" and cannot be misled, unlike those who were "illiterate" in Gujarat and some other places.

"Do they agree with this statement? If Rahul Gandhi has any sense, he should distance himself from this remark, condemn it, and demand an apology," Prasad said.

The former Union minister said Kharge "does not deserve to remain Congress president" for making such comments, and questioned if he had "abandoned all sense of dignity."

"The position he holds was once occupied by leaders such as Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Dr Rajendra Prasad, Maulana Azad, Sonia Gandhi, Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi, and even Rahul Gandhi. What kind of language is being used by someone holding such a post? Kharge's comment is not only demeaning, but shameless and utterly despicable," he said.

"What does it mean when the president of a national party calls an entire state's people illiterate? I want to pose a serious question to the party's national platform," he added.



BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad

Prasad said Gujarat has produced several national leaders and intellectuals, and its literacy rate has improved over the years to around 82 per cent.

"Kharge said Gujaratis are illiterate and that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has misled them to stay in power, while people of Kerala are educated. Will you say anything without thinking because you hate the prime minister!" said the MP from Patna Sahib.

He demanded that the Congress president apologise to the people of Gujarat, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh.

"Kharge, you owe an apology to the country. On

Infiltrators will be sent back once BJP comes to power in Bengal: Amit Shah

TONY DAS ■ Silchar

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday asserted that a "parivartan" (change) is inevitable in West Bengal and claimed that once the BJP comes to power in the eastern state, infiltrators would be sent back to their countries.

Addressing election rallies in Assam's Barak Valley, including in Patharkandi, Sribhumi and Hailakandi, Shah alleged that the Congress gave shelter to illegal immigrants in the region, making them "predominant" in Sribhumi and Cachar districts.

He claimed that the party opposed the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) as it prevents infiltrators from remaining in the State. "Persecuted Hindus from Bangladesh come within the ambit of this law...the Congress is opposed to this, but the party lays out a red carpet to welcome Muslim infiltrators", Shah alleged. Claiming that India is not a 'dharamshala' (guest house),



Union Home Minister Amit Shah at the Vijay Sankalp Samaroh in Patharkandi, Assam PIONEER PHOTO

the BJP leader said there is "no place for infiltrators" in the country.

"A 'parivartan' (change) is inevitable in West Bengal. Once the BJP comes to power in the State, all infiltrators from Assam, Tripura and Bengal will be sent back to their countries," Shah said. He alleged that the Congress wants to return to power with the "help of infiltrators, but Rahul Baba must know that his three generations cannot make Assam a land of infiltrators".

Addressing another rally in Hailakandi, Shah claimed the Congress had built 700 madrasas for Muslim stu-

dents in Assam, but the "BJP converted 402 of them into primary schools so that they can also have access to modern education."

In the final rally of his campaign at Silchar, he said that Assam's prosperity can be assured only by removing the infiltrators from the State. The names of infiltrators are being removed from the electoral rolls by the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), but "Mamata didi aur Rahul Baba ke pet me dard ho raha hain (they are suffering from stomach ache). Let them cry and beat their chests as much as they want, but infiltrators have to go."

KC Venugopal poses 10 questions to Kerala CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

AICC general secretary KC Venugopal on Tuesday released an open letter addressed to Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, raising a string of allegations and questions over the LDF Government's functioning, on the day public campaigning ended ahead of the April 9 Assembly polls.

In the letter, Venugopal said that as Kerala stands at the threshold of another election, several questions remain in the minds of the people regarding Vijayan's 10-year tenure, and sought answers to what he described as the "most discussed" issues in the State.

He posed 10 questions to the Chief Minister, alleging "secret deals" with BJP leaders and the Centre on multiple matters. Among the issues flagged were Vijayan's meeting with Union Home Minister Amit Shah at his residence in New Delhi



KC Venugopal

without officials present, and a breakfast meeting hosted for FM Nirmala Sitharaman at Kerala House, questioning the agenda and purpose behind such interactions.

Venugopal also referred to meetings with Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, asking whether any discussions held outside official settings were part of an alleged understanding.

He further questioned the State Government's (later withdrawn) decision to implement the PM SHRI scheme despite Opposition from CPI leaders within the ruling front, alleging that it was done after reaching an understanding with the BJP.

High-voltage Assam campaign wraps up under shadows of accusations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

The high-voltage campaign, fraught with accusations and promises galore, for the elections to the 126-member Assam Assembly ended at 5 pm on Tuesday.

The polls will be held on April 9 to decide the electoral fate of 722 candidates.

BJP leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, attacked the Opposition Congress, accusing it of encouraging infiltrators to settle down in Assam's land to create a vote bank, and failing to control insurgency and usher in development and employment during its rule.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma upped the ante by directly attacking Bengali-speaking Muslims of immigrant origin, derogatorily



Assam CM Himanta at an election rally in Sivsagar PIONEER PHOTO

called the 'Miyas', claiming that during the last five years, "he has broken their arms and legs" and in the next five "he will break their backbones".

The ruling party in the State asserted that it provided land ownership rights to tea garden workers, empowerment schemes to women, financial assistance for girl

students, and brought down child marriage by 84 per cent.

The BJP leaders claimed the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) will be implemented in the State to prevent polygamy and promised that the journey of development will continue.

The Opposition Congress and its alliance partners have accused the BJP of practising

the 'politics of hate', indulging in widespread corruption, particularly by the CM and his family members, lopsided development, and not being serious about ensuring justice to popular singer Zubeen Garg, who died in Singapore on September 19 last year.

The Congress said that if voted to power, it would provide justice for Garg, cash assistance to women, a health insurance scheme to people, land rights for indigenous people and others.

The chief minister accused State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi and his wife of having links with Pakistan's spy agency ISI. On the other hand, the Opposition party charged Sarma's wife Riniki Bhuyan Sharma with owning multiple passports, properties in Dubai and assets in shell companies, which her husband did not mention in his poll affidavit.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) appears on course for a decisive victory in the upcoming Kerala Assembly elections, with a new survey projecting the alliance to secure between 88 and 92 seats in the 140-member House — well above the majority mark of 70.

According to the Poll Mantra Intelligence Report, the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) is expected to see a sharp decline, with projections placing it at 42-46 seats. The BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA), meanwhile, is forecast to win between 0 and 2 seats, underscoring its continued struggle to translate vote share into electoral gains in the State.

The survey characterises



the election as a potentially "one-sided contest," driven by what it calls a "structured voter shift" rather than a fragmented swing. Anti-incumbency has emerged as the dominant factor influencing voter sentiment.

In terms of vote share, the UDF leads with 41.5%, followed by the LDF at 33.4%. The NDA stands at 17.2%, while other parties account for 2.3%. Only 5.6% of voters remain undecided, indicating that preferences are largely settled ahead of polling.

The UDF is projected to dominate across all regions: Malabar (60 seats): UDF 41-43, LDF 15-17, Central Kerala (41 seats): UDF 25-26, LDF 12-13

Travancore (39 seats): UDF 22-23, LDF 15-16.

While Travancore shows a relatively closer contest, the UDF still maintains a clear edge.

The survey highlights a "desire for change" as the primary voting driver, influencing 22.8% of voters. Welfare benefits follow at 17.6%, while

ideology and party values account for 16.2%. Leadership preferences (14.6%), past government performance (12.1%), and local candidates (9.4%) play smaller but notable roles.

"Kerala voters are leaning towards a performance-plus-change narrative, rather than identity politics," the report notes, adding that welfare schemes alone are insufficient without strong leadership perception.

Among preferred Chief Ministerial candidates, VD Satheeshan leads with 21.3% support, followed by incumbent Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan at 18.5%. Ramesh Chennithala (17.2%) and KC Venugopal (15.1%) remain key contenders, while BJP's Rajeev Chandrashekhara trails at 9.6%.

In terms of recent momentum, however, Venugopal leads with 19.4%, narrowly ahead of Vijayan (18.6%) and Shashi Tharoor (18.2%).

Puducherry has become testing ground for BJP's anti-people policies: Udhayanidhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puducherry

Tamil Nadu Deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin on Tuesday claimed that the BJP wanted to take full control of the Union Territory just as it wanted to gain control of Tamil Nadu through Edappadi K Palaniswami-led AIADMK.

Campaigning for the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance candidates, Udhayanidhi said Puducherry people never allowed hate politics "in this land of love".

"Today in such UT, the infil-



tration of fascist BJP forces has increased significantly. It has become a testing ground for all of the BJP's anti-people policies. It is riding on the shoulders of AINRC, just as it is riding on the shoulders of

Palaniswami-led AIADMK in Tamil Nadu," he said.

The BJP's anti-people policies include the National Education Policy, and through it, the caste-based education system (kula kalvi thittam) has been introduced, he alleged.

"They are implementing schemes that would ruin the future generations in Puducherry. But Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin effectively halted the BJP's conspiracies from entering the State," Udhayanidhi said while addressing a poll rally in Mudaliarpet.

LDF delayed Wayanad housing project, claims Priyanka Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Wayanad (Kerala)

Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi on Tuesday claimed that the party's housing project for victims of the Mundakkai-Chooralmala landslides was delayed due to lack of clearances from the ruling Left Government in Kerala.

Priyanka, addressing a UDF corner meeting at Kalpetta, claimed that the clearances were given for the project of Congress only



after the township of the LDF was inaugurated.

"I am sure my colleagues in the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) faced the same problems," she contended.

Her remarks come amidst

allegations of irregularities against Congress in connection with its collection of funds for the Wayanad housing project and utilisation of the money, putting the party on the back foot.

Priyanka also attacked Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, questioning why there were no cases against him, despite facing several corruption accusations, when those opposing Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP are facing probes by central agencies.

TMC diverted central funds to party activities, alleges Pradhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Tuesday accused the TMC Government in West Bengal of diverting central funds towards party activities, asserting that the State's education system has been "destroyed".

Pradhan was addressing the media at Kolkata's Kalighat temple, where he joined BJP's Rashbehari candidate Swapan Dasgupta to offer prayers.

"The Central Government



extended funds for mid-day meals, books and dresses. All that money was spent on party activities. Education in Bengal has been destroyed," he claimed.

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Order Order

Urgent cases to be mentioned only before CJI-led bench: SC



In a significant procedural directive, the Supreme Court has said that “exceptionally urgent matters” that cannot wait for the listing process have to be mentioned only before the Chief Justice of India (CJI), even if he is busy presiding over a constitution bench.

According to the usual practice, urgent matters are mentioned for listing and hearing before the seniormost judge of the apex court if the CJI is either unavailable or busy heading a constitution bench.

In a circular issued on April 6, the top court said, “Mentioning of exceptionally urgent matters, which cannot await listing before the Hon’ble Court as per circular dated November 29, 2025, is permitted before Court no 1, even when the Hon’ble Chief Justice is presiding over a constitution bench.”

The circular said that the mentioning of such matters is not permitted before any other bench.

Punjab and Haryana HC bars judicial officers from using AI tools to write judgments



The Punjab and Haryana High Court has asked judicial officers not to use AI tools such as ChatGPT, Gemini and Copilot to write judgments and conduct legal research.

A letter issued by the High Court registrar-general on Monday to all district and sessions judges in Punjab, Haryana and Chandigarh stated that the Chief Justice has asked them “to direct the judicial officers working under your control not to use Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools, including but not limited to ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, Meta, et cetera, for writing of judgments and legal research. Any violation of these instructions will be viewed seriously.”

Earlier, the Gujarat High Court had prohibited the use of AI for any form of decision-making, judicial reasoning, order drafting, judgment preparation, bail sentencing considerations, or any substantive adjudicatory process.

According to the Gujarat High Court’s AI policy, unveiled at a conference of district judiciary judges on Saturday, artificial intelligence should be used to improve the speed and quality of justice delivery, rather than as a replacement for judicial reasoning.

Centre to SC: CCTV issues in police stations will be settled in 2 weeks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Tuesday told the Supreme Court that all issues concerning the installation of CCTVs in police stations across the country would be sorted out within two weeks.

Attorney General R Venkataramani told a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta that he was taking stock of the issue and a lot of things were happening.

The Union home secretary also appeared in court in pursuance of the apex court’s April 6 order asking him to remain present before it on Tuesday so that appropriate assistance might be drawn from him in implementation of the scheme for installation of CCTVs in police stations.

The top court was hearing a batch of pleas, including a suo motu case over the lack of functional CCTVs in police stations. “I am taking stock of the issues,” the attorney general told the bench.

Justice Nath said the top court had earlier asked the amicus curiae in the matter



to hold meetings with all the states and Union Territories (UTs), and the Union of India was represented by an under secretary in the deliberations.

“Does it look nice?” Justice Nath said.

The top law officer said a lot of things are happening in the matter and he would have a series of meetings with the amicus and the home secretary.

The bench said during the hearing on Monday, it was pointed out that Kerala has come out with a very nice software and they have implemented it fully.



Centre backs restriction on women’s entry in Sabarimala

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Backing the restriction on the entry of women of menstruating age into Kerala’s Sabarimala temple, the Centre on Tuesday told the Supreme Court that the issue falls squarely within the domain of religious faith and denominational autonomy, and lies beyond the scope of judicial review.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, told a nine-judge Constitution bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant that if there is something unscientific, the remedy is with the legislature.

“We have to respect every denomination’s practice; not everything is related to dignity or bodily freedom. If I go to a mazar or a gurudwara and if I have to cover my head, I can’t say my dignity, right or choice is taken away,” Mehta told the bench, also comprising Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi.

Mehta said if someone claims that human sacrifice is an essential religious practice and approaches the court under Article 32 of the

Constitution, then the court need not examine whether it is religious or essential, and reject it on the ground that it directly violates public order, morality or health.

“It is submitted that the court should expressly decline a model of review that asks whether a practice is ‘rational’, ‘modern’, ‘scientifically defensible’, ‘acceptable to judicial sensibilities’, ‘unpopular views’ or based upon broad and subjective ‘doctrines’ of ‘transformative constitutionalism’ or ‘constitutional morality’. Such an inquiry is not constitutional review; rather, it would be a substitution of judicial philosophy for religious self-understanding, depending upon the subjective view of the bench, which is not trained in interpreting religious texts.

“The Constitution protects religious freedom precisely because the protected field contains convictions, rituals, disciplines, and forms of worship that may not satisfy secular standards of reason, utility or majoritarian taste,” Mehta said.

The solicitor general submitted that the doctrine of “constitutional morality” is not precisely defined in the Constitution.

“It is pertinent to note that ‘constitutional morality’ is not textually present in the Constitution. Rather,



it is a judicially evolved, vague and indeterminate concept. Hence, the expansion of the term ‘morality’ — which is explicitly referred to in the Constitution to mean and include ‘constitutional morality’ — amounts to not only judicial overreach but an amendment of the Constitution,” the Centre said. The Centre submitted that there is an inherent risk in the court exercising its jurisdiction to interpret any religion.

“Apart from the fact that the court would not possess either expertise or scholarship on religious issues,

holy books, scriptures, texts, et cetera, further in the context of

India, which does not follow only one particular theistic religion but has a pluralistic society including Hindus, Muslims, Christians and other religions... each religion has its different sections or denominations, and each denomination and section has their own faith, belief and expression for worship. The founding fathers were fully conscious of this pluralism of the country and the internal pluralism amongst each religion,” the Centre said.

At the outset, the top court asked counsels for the parties to adhere to the timeline, and said it will not

Delhi Assembly breach: Court sends SUV driver to 8 days of police custody

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Tuesday sent the SUV driver accused of driving into the Delhi Assembly premises to eight days of police custody.

The accused, Sarabjeet Singh, was produced before Judicial Magistrate Kartik Tapparai on Tuesday. The police initially sought 10 days of police custody but were granted eight days.

Singh, 37, is believed to be a “follower of the Kisan Andolan (farmers’ agitation)”. He has shared several posts on social media platforms expressing support for farmer leaders who lost their lives during the 2020-21 agitation. Some of this content was later deleted either by him or by the original posters.

A senior police officer said that Singh drove the vehicle in a “dangerous manner with apparent intent to run over



Police personnel inspect after an SUV driven by a masked man forced its way through one of the boundary gates of the Delhi Assembly premises in New Delhi on Monday (FILE PHOTO)

security personnel on duty, thereby endangering their lives”. The SUV, bearing a Uttar Pradesh registration from Pilibhit, rammed through Gate no

2 around 2 pm. It approached from the Delhi University side, took a sharp turn, broke the boom barriers, and entered the premises, police said.

Two British nationals jailed for illegal entry into India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bahrach (UP)

A court has sentenced two British nationals to six months’ imprisonment for illegally entering India from Nepal, officials said on Tuesday.

Chief Judicial Magistrate Pratibha Chowdhry on Monday also imposed a fine of ₹50,000 on each of the convicts. In case of default in payment of the fine, they will have to undergo an additional three months’ imprisonment.

The court, however, granted them bail after pronouncement of the sentence on the condition that they will not leave the country during the appeal period.

According to prosecution officer Nirmal Yadav, the two — Hassan Amman Saleem (35) and Sumitra Shakeel



Olivia (61) — were arrested in November last year from the Indo-Nepal border at Rupaideha for entering India without valid documents. Saleem, originally from Gujranwala in Pakistan, is a resident of Manchester, United Kingdom, and works as a lecturer in audiology at the De Montfort University.

Olivia, originally from Udupi in Karnataka, later acquired British citizenship and resides in Gloucester, UK. She holds a

British passport as well as an Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) card.

Yadav said the two had travelled from the UK to Nepal in November 2025 to participate in a charity programme for hearing-impaired children at a medical college in Nepalgunj. They were holding valid Nepal visas.

On November 15, 2025, personnel of the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) and the Uttar Pradesh Police intercepted

them during a joint checking drive at the International Border as they attempted to enter India.

They were found to be without valid documents for entry into the country and were subsequently arrested under relevant provisions of the Immigration and Foreigners Act.

After spending some time in jail, the duo was granted bail by the court on the condition that they would not leave the country.

Since then, they had been attending court hearings regularly, staying mostly in hotels in Bahrach during the trial. Based on the evidence and circumstances, the court found both accused guilty and awarded the sentence, observing that punishment in cases of illegal entry is necessary to ensure compliance with the law, Yadav said.

Disqualified MP Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti moves Delhi HC in cheating case



Disqualified Madhya Pradesh Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Disqualified Madhya Pradesh Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti on Tuesday moved the Delhi High Court challenging his conviction and three-year jail sentence in a cheating case involving the forging of bank records to obtain illegal interest payments between 1998 and 2011.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma issued notice to the prosecution on the appeal by Bharti assailing the trial court verdict in the case and listed it for hearing on April 15.

On April 2, the trial court sentenced Bharti, former chairperson of the Zila Sahkari Krishi Aur Grahmin Vikas Bank, to three years’ imprisonment in the case.

Underlining that restitution would serve justice better than physical incarceration, the trial court also imposed a fine of ₹1 lakh on Bharti, which would go to the Madhya Pradesh Sahkari Krishi Avem Gramin Vikas Bank Seemit, Bhopal, as the complainant bank had undergone liquidation.

The trial court convicted Bharti on April 1 under Indian

Penal Code (IPC) Sections 120B (criminal conspiracy), 420 (cheating), 467 (forgery of a valuable security), 468 (forgery for cheating) and 471 (using a forged document as genuine).

Bharti was admitted to bail for a period of 60 days and sentence was suspended by the trial court to enable him to file appeal(s) before the High Court in the present matter.

The case, which originated in Madhya Pradesh’s Datia, was transferred to Delhi by the Supreme Court in October last year, in light of the claim that efforts were made to intimidate defence witnesses.

In the verdict, the trial court said, “Accused Bharti and accused Raghuvir Sharan Prajapati, along with Savitri Devi (deceased) and possibly other unknown persons, entered into a criminal conspiracy and the object of this conspiracy was to cheat the complainant bank (Zila Sahkari Krishi Aur Grahmin Vikas Bank) by continuing to draw interest at a much higher rate beyond 2011, which was the initial fixed deposit (FD) duration of three years.”

Modern courts key to justice delivery: J&K CM, reviews new HC project

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jammu

J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Tuesday said modern court infrastructure is key to ensuring efficient justice delivery and strengthening public trust in the legal system.

Chairing a high-level meeting to review the progress of construction of High Court complexes in the twin capital cities of Jammu and Srinagar, he reiterated his government’s commitment to augmenting judicial infrastructure and institutional capacity in both divisions.

The meeting was attended by Advisor to the Chief Minister Nasir Aslam Wani, Chief Secretary Atal Dullloo and representatives of National Buildings Construction Corporation Ltd (NBCC), among others, an official spokesperson said.

Emphasising time-bound completion and inter-departmental coordination, Abdullah called for early grant of administrative



J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah

approval for the Jammu wing at Raika.

“The modern court infrastructure is essential for efficient justice delivery and public trust in the legal system,” the chief minister said and directed officials to ensure adherence to time-lines, quality benchmarks and transparency in execution.

The project, being executed by NBCC, involves the relocation of the existing High Court from Janipur to a purpose-built campus at Raika in Jammu, envisioned

as a modern, integrated judicial complex.

A detailed presentation outlining the key aspects of the project was delivered in the meeting, where NBCC officials informed that the project is being executed in multiple phases to ensure structured development and optimal resource utilisation.

The CM also reviewed proposals for the redevelopment of the Lower Court Complex in Srinagar, the spokesperson added.



Editor's
TAKE

Indian economy faces headwinds

With war raging in West Asia and the impact of Trump tariffs showing up, the Indian economy is going through a lean patch, with the rupee falling and stocks down

The Indian economy, one of the fastest-growing economies in the world, is under stress. India has had a strong run so far, but it is now showing signs of slowing down. Though the overall movement of the economy is still positive, the momentum is sluggish. GDP growth has been less encouraging compared to earlier highs and may have to be lowered for the present fiscal year. Private consumption remains weak, reflecting pressure on incomes and uneven demand. Industrial activity is down. Another big concern is that investments are also not up to the mark, with private sector participation becoming cautious; government spending is the only factor holding it up. Exports have also slowed due to weak global demand, affecting key sectors. Meanwhile, inflation - particularly in food - has reduced purchasing power, further dampening demand. Financial markets have reacted sharply. Benchmark indices such as the BSE Sensex and the Nifty 50 have corrected by over 10 per cent since late February, wiping out massive investor wealth.

Employment concerns due to slow job creation are affecting economic growth. Ironically, high-end consumption is strong, but mass demand is subdued, making it a cause for concern. Together, these trends indicate a gradual economic slowdown or heating up of the economy. Due to these factors, Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) have pulled out nearly \$12 billion in March alone - the highest-ever monthly outflow. The downside of the rupee, which is at an all-time low of 95 against the dollar, is making imports expensive and adding to inflationary pressures. Fiscal measures are needed to correct these trends, consolidate, and prevent the economy from going into a downward spiral.

Global shocks - ranging from geopolitical tensions in West Asia to rising protectionism in the United States - a weakening rupee, falling stock markets, and a perceptible slowdown in growth momentum need immediate intervention from the Government. The slowdown is not merely external. Domestic demand, particularly in rural India, remains subdued due to sluggish income growth. High inflation has eroded household purchasing power, dampening consumption - the backbone of India's GDP. Manufacturing growth remains uneven, and job creation continues to lag behind, unable to absorb the young and expanding workforce.

The net result is a clear deceleration in economic momentum. The way out lies in short-term stabilisation and long-term structural reform that addresses the vulnerabilities of importing oil. First, macroeconomic stability must be prioritised. The Reserve Bank of India needs to strike a delicate balance between controlling inflation and supporting growth. The government must manage fiscal pressures prudently while protecting capital expenditure, particularly in infrastructure. Navigating this turbulent phase will require policy agility, strategic foresight, and a renewed focus on inclusive growth. India has weathered many storms in the past, and with the right mix of prudent fiscal management and effective diplomacy, it will pass this test as well, with flying colours.

West Bengal: Will it be Mamata all the way again?

West Bengal is headed for a high-stakes electoral battle, with Mamata Banerjee poised to secure a historic fourth consecutive term even as the Bharatiya Janata Party mounts its strongest challenge yet



KALYANI SHANKAR

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee is likely to secure a historic fourth term in office, according to the latest opinion poll projections. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is gaining ground in the state and is ambitious enough to challenge Mamata's position. Meanwhile, both the Congress and the Communist Party of India (CPI) have lost their influence. The key message for Mamata is that the BJP's rise has come at the expense of these traditional parties.

The political contest in Bengal has intensified, rendering this election a significant moment for the state. This dynamic fosters a highly competitive political landscape. The TMC holds a clear advantage, with 119 seats categorised as very strong and an additional 95 as strong. Mamata Banerjee is facing her former aide and BJP candidate, Suwendu Adhikari, in the Nandigram constituency. The BJP has projected Suwendu as its chief ministerial face.

The BJP has concentrated its campaign on criticising the Trinamool Congress (TMC) for Mamata Banerjee's 15 years in office. Last week, Union Home Minister Amit Shah released a chargesheet against the West Bengal government, addressing Banerjee as "Mamata ji" or "Didi" while expressing his criticisms of her leadership.

In the 2021 West Bengal elections, the TMC achieved a significant victory, securing 215 seats. This demonstrated a notable political shift. In contrast, the BJP won 77 seats, highlighting its increasing influence in the state.

Voting patterns along religious and caste lines reveal how different communities support the TMC and the BJP, making every vote crucial to the election's outcome.

Regions like Medinipur and Malda, with high seat turnover, are key battlegrounds that could determine the election's direction.

Banerjee has called on voters to see her as the candidate for all 294 state Assembly seats, not just individual TMC candidates. She accused the BJP of trying to illegally add voters from Bihar, Rajasthan, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh to West Bengal's electoral rolls, claiming they plan to transport these voters by train using methods similar to those used in Bihar.

The slogan "Jai Maa Durga" has replaced "Jai Shree Ram". This change highlights the importance of the Goddess in Bengal's culture.

Around 125 constituencies in West Bengal have mainly Muslim populations, with the Trinamool Congress (TMC) winning over 100,



MAMATA BANERJEE HAS ACCUSED BJP AGENTS OF FLOODING WEST BENGAL'S ELECTORAL ROLLS WITH FAKE FORM 6 APPLICATIONS TO INCLUDE OUTSIDERS. SHE URGED THE ELECTION COMMISSION TO PROTECT DEMOCRATIC RIGHTS

The writer, is a popular columnist

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The Pioneer

giving it a strong advantage. Unlike in the 2021 elections, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is now focusing less on religious themes in its campaign.

The BJP aims to avoid religious divisions in the upcoming elections, unlike in 2021. With over 30 per cent of voters being Muslim, past divisions have harmed its support. To soften its approach, it now uses the term "outsiders". This insiders-versus-outsiders theme gives Mamata an advantage.

Mamata, a determined leader, rose to power in 2011 by ousting a Communist-led government that had ruled West Bengal for 34 years and has since retained her position.

The TMC is not very structured and lacks strict rules. It also lacks a strong set of beliefs. Like many regional parties in India, it depends on the strong leadership of Mamata Banerjee, who is affectionately known as the "fire goddess" by her supporters.

A BJP victory in West Bengal would give the party a significant edge, especially since Narendra Modi, despite being the most popular leader in India, has struggled in state elections. Winning in a state with a sizeable Muslim electorate would carry strong symbolic weight and diminish any remaining chances for the fragmented opposition to challenge Modi's organised party in the 2024 general elections.

The disagreement over fish, considered lucky in Bengal and important for starting new projects, escalated when the Trinamool Congress accused the BJP of wanting to ban

non-vegetarian food. Mamata Banerjee has accused BJP agents of flooding West Bengal's electoral rolls with fake Form 6 applications to include outsiders. She urged the Election Commission to protect democratic rights.

Despite significant resources, the BJP's efforts to secure Fort William and establish its first government in West Bengal have not reached the halfway mark in the Assembly election.

The campaign trail has shifted from speeches to political intimacy, with candidates conveying a single message: "I am not above you; I am one among you."

A slew of welfare schemes — bicycles and scholarships for students, cash transfers for girl students to continue education, and health insurance — has ensured that Banerjee's populist appeal remains unblemished. She remains popular with women voters; some 17 per cent of her candidates in this election are women.

Despite the ailing Communists stitching up an alliance with a Muslim cleric and the enfeebled Congress to swing votes away from the main contestants, the battle for West Bengal is singularly bipolar. To win the state, a party has to capture 45 per cent of the popular vote. Most analysts believe that Mamata Banerjee will win. She has an edge over her rivals right now. The BJP is working on the ground with the RSS's help, and top BJP leaders are in Kolkata. Mamata has learned from the CPI(M) how to stay in power. Whether these strategies will work for her this time is the big question.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

PIC TALK



Members of the Konyak community during the Aoling festival at Longwa village in Mon district, Nagaland. PHOTO: PTI

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History's greatest lesson: Transform yourself



RAJYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

The vast expanse of human history is not merely a catalogue of past events; it is a dynamic and evolving narrative of change. Across centuries, it unfolds as a sequence of moments — some similar, others strikingly different - that together shape the story of human civilisation. These moments are more than dates or isolated incidents; they reflect the actions, choices, and experiences of individuals and communities. Preserved through oral traditions, inscriptions, coins, pictographs, and written records, history consistently reveals one enduring truth: it is fundamentally a record of transformation.

This process of transformation operates at every level of human existence. Civilisations rise and decline, nations grow and adapt, cities flourish or fade, and even small communities undergo constant change. At the centre of these

developments are individuals whose lives mark critical turning points. Again and again, history demonstrates that meaningful societal change often begins with personal transformation. A closer look reveals a common pattern — deep reflection, followed by realisation, and ultimately a firm resolve to change. This sequence has repeatedly led to profound moral and spiritual growth, influencing not just individuals but entire societies.

The story of Saint Valmiki illustrates this power of inner change. Once a robber who preyed on travellers, he lived without questioning the morality of his actions. However, an encounter with sages forced him to confront a difficult truth: the burden of his sins would be his alone. This realisation sparked a deep transformation within him. Renouncing his past, he evolved into a compassionate sage and went on to compose the Ramayana, a timeless epic celebrating righteousness and virtue.

A similar journey of transformation is evident in the life of Gautam Buddha. His encounters with illness, old age, and death prompted him to reflect deeply on human suffering. This reflection led him to seek answers, ultimately discovering a path to liberation. His personal awakening became a universal message that continues to guide millions. Emperor Ashoka's transformation after the Kalinga war further reinforces this theme. Witnessing the devastation caused by his conquest, he recognised the futil-

ity of violence and embraced peace and dharma, reshaping both his life and his empire.

Similarly, Mahatma Gandhi's transformation began with an act of humiliation when he was thrown off a train in South Africa. That experience awakened his sense of dignity and justice, leading him to dedicate his life to India's freedom. His personal resolve ultimately mobilised an entire nation.

These examples highlight a powerful truth: lasting change begins within. Reflection gives rise to awareness, awareness leads to determination, and determination results in meaningful action. Through this process, individuals transcend their limitations and inspire others, creating a ripple effect that transforms society.

However, such transformation is not easy. The greatest barrier often lies within — resistance to change, complacency, or lack of will. Yet, in a world filled with uncertainty, the need for inner transformation is more urgent than ever. True fulfilment can only be achieved by aligning one's actions with higher values.

Change begins with the individual. Ultimately, the responsibility for a better world rests with each of us, as even small personal changes can create far-reaching impact.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

STRONGER MISSILE SHIELD STRENGTHENS INDIA'S STRATEGIC DEFENCE CAPABILITIES

India's plan to develop a lighter intercontinental missile capable of overcoming advanced defence systems such as THAAD and the S-500 is a clear sign of the country's evolving strategic vision. As modern warfare becomes increasingly dependent on cutting-edge technology, India's efforts to upgrade its missile capabilities are both timely and necessary for national security.

The proposed missile is important not just for its range, but for the technological edge it promises to deliver. A lighter and more advanced system could improve speed, manoeuvrability, and operational efficiency, making it more capable of penetrating sophisticated air defence networks. This would significantly strengthen India's deterrence posture and ensure preparedness for future security challenges.

However, such military progress must always be balanced with India's commitment to peace and responsible defence policy. Strengthening strategic capabilities should aim at preserving stability and discouraging threats rather than escalating tensions. India's defence modernisation must continue to reflect the principles of restraint, self-defence, and regional balance.

This development also highlights the growing strength of India's indigenous scientific and defence research capabilities. With sustained focus and careful execution, such advancements can bolster national security and reinforce India's image as a technologically capable and strategically mature nation.

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Amul's model inspires India

Amul's journey from a modest cooperative in Anand to a Rs 1 trillion enterprise is a remarkable testament to the power of collective effort. Under the stewardship of the Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation, it has not only achieved scale but also sustained growth, challenging the notion that cooperatives are inefficient.

The vision of Verghese Kurien transformed India from a milk-deficient nation into the world's largest producer. Today, millions of farmers contribute to a vast network that delivers quality products across the globe. What sets Amul apart is its integration of sustainability and technology. From solar-powered infrastructure to digital tools that empower farmers with real-time data, the cooperative has embraced innovation while staying rooted in its principles.

Equally significant is its social impact. Women-led village societies and profit-sharing mechanisms have strengthened rural economies and promoted equity. Amul's transparent governance and strong distribution systems further reinforce its credibility.

Policymakers should take note. Replicating this model in sectors such as agriculture, fisheries, and handicrafts can ensure that growth is inclusive and benefits grassroots stakeholders, not just large corporations.

S K PRABHAKAR | GURUGRAM

Justice delivered in custodial case

The recent verdict awarding the death penalty to nine police personnel in the Thoothukudi custodial death case marks a decisive moment in upholding justice. The judgment reinforces the principle that those entrusted with enforcing the law must be held to the highest standards of accountability.

The case shocked the nation, exposing the misuse of authority and the vulnerability of individuals in custody. By delivering a stringent punishment, the court has sent a clear message that custodial violence will not be tolerated. Many believe that such a verdict serves as a strong deterrent against future misconduct.

However, justice must go beyond punishment. This case underscores the urgent need for systemic police reforms, improved training, and robust oversight mechanisms. Ensuring transparency and accountability within law enforcement institutions is essential to rebuilding public trust.

While the verdict provides closure to the victims' families, it should also act as a catalyst for long-term change. Preventing such incidents in the future must remain a national priority, ensuring that justice is not only delivered but also sustained.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Making disability inclusion central to India’s agenda

For too long, disability has remained at the margins of India’s political discourse - acknowledged in law but insufficiently understood in practice. Bridging this gap requires more than legislation; it demands informed, sensitive, and proactive engagement from lawmakers

FIRST
Column



ARMAN
ALI

When I speak about disability rights and empowerment, I return to a simple but urgent truth — India’s Parliament must not just acknowledge the issues of persons with disabilities; it must understand them deeply and act on them decisively. Sensitising Members of Parliament and clearly defining their role in advancing inclusion is essential to building a truly equitable society.

It is with this conviction that we at the National Centre for Promotion of Employment for Disabled People have brought out *Beyond the Visible: A Handbook on Disability Inclusion for Parliamentarians*.

The objective is clear: to enable policymakers to engage with disability in a more informed, sensitive, and effective manner, and to translate legislative intent into meaningful action.

The RPWD Act, 2016 clearly defines disability as a long-term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairment which hinders a person’s full and effective participation in society. It also states that a person’s environment largely affects their experience and extent of disability. When the law itself recognises that environments shape disability, the path forward is undeniable: make those environments accessible. Ensuring this — across infrastructure and digital systems — is the responsibility of lawmakers and legislators.

For far too long, disability in India has remained on the margins of political discourse. Despite progressive legislation like the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, which expanded recognition to 21 disabilities and shifted the framework from welfare to rights, implementation gaps persist. Disability continues to be underrepresented in parliamentary engagements and debates, policy priorities, and budgetary allocations. The issue today is not the absence of laws, but the depth of their understanding and the seriousness of their execution.

This is where the handbook intervenes. It is not an academic document; it is a practical tool designed to support parliamentarians in their day-to-day legislative respon-



INDIA’S VISION OF BECOMING A VIKSIT BHARAT RESTS ON INCLUSIVE GROWTH. THIS VISION CANNOT BE REALISED IF MILLIONS REMAIN EXCLUDED FROM DECISION-MAKING PROCESSES

The writer is the Executive Director of the National Centre for Promotion of Employment for Disabled Persons (NCPEDP)

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sibilities. It helps them frame more informed questions, adopt appropriate and respectful language, and recognise disability as a cross-cutting issue that intersects with health, education, employment, and governance. I strongly feel that the way disability is discussed in Parliament — whether through Zero Hour interventions or questions tabled on the floor — can significantly shape both public perception and policy outcomes.

At a global level, the importance of political inclusion is well recognised. Article 29 of the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities affirms the right of persons with disabilities to participate fully in political and public life. This includes not just the right to vote, but also the right to be represented, influence decisions, and take part in governance. India’s own law reflects this thinking. The RPWD Act, 2016 also recognises political barriers as a form of exclusion faced by persons with disabilities - an important first in the country’s legal framework.

For India, this means ensuring that disability is not seen as a side issue,

but as a core part of how our democracy functions.

The timing of this initiative is particularly significant. With Census 2027 approaching, India has a historic opportunity to generate accurate and disaggregated data across all 21 recognised disabilities. Reliable data is the foundation of effective policymaking. Without it, inclusion remains rhetorical; with it, interventions can be targeted, budgets can be justified, and progress can be measured.

At the same time, lived experiences continue to reveal systemic gaps that require urgent attention. Take, for instance, the issue of assistive devices — an area that often remains overlooked in policy discussions. For persons with disabilities, devices like wheelchairs are not conveniences; they are essential for mobility, independence, and participation in everyday life. Yet, access, affordability, and maintenance remain significant challenges. Even in my own journey, securing insurance for a wheelchair — something

that should be a basic safeguard — required sustained effort and engagement. It highlighted a larger policy gap: the absence of structured support systems for assistive devices within mainstream insurance frameworks.

This concern becomes even more pressing when we look at healthcare. A recent survey by NCPEDP revealed that over 80% of persons with disabilities in India lack access to any form of health insurance. High premiums, exclusion of disability-related conditions, and denial of coverage continue to create barriers. This is not just a policy gap — it is a question of equity and dignity.

Flagship schemes like Ayushman Bharat have the potential to address these challenges, but only if they are made truly inclusive. Persons with disabilities require comprehensive, life-long support, including assistive devices, rehabilitation, and specialised care. Inclusion must be designed into these systems from the outset. The handbook

BEYOND THE VISIBLE IS BOTH A GUIDE AND A CALL TO ACTION. ULTIMATELY, THE SUCCESS OF THIS INITIATIVE WILL NOT BE MEASURED BY ITS LAUNCH, BUT BY ITS USE. IF IT LEADS TO MORE INFORMED DEBATES, STRONGER POLICIES, AND MORE INCLUSIVE SYSTEMS, IT WILL HAVE ACHIEVED ITS PURPOSE

also builds on a broader effort to mainstream disability within political discourse. Over the years, sustained engagement with lawmakers has reinforced a consistent message — disability is not a niche issue; it is central to governance. Political participation, accessible institutions, and inclusive policies are critical to ensuring that persons with disabilities are not just beneficiaries, but active contributors to India’s development.

India’s vision of becoming a Viksit Bharat rests on inclusive growth. This vision cannot be realised if millions remain excluded from decision-making processes. Persons with disabilities are equal citizens with rights, aspirations, and capabilities. Recognising this is the first step; embedding it into governance is the real challenge.

Beyond the Visible is both a guide and a call to action. Ultimately, the success of this initiative will not be measured by its launch, but by its use. If it leads to more informed debates, stronger policies, and more inclusive systems, it will have achieved its purpose.

Rescuing citizens from war zones: India’s strategic resolve



KUNWAR
PUSHPENDRA
PRATAP
SINGH

In an increasingly conflict-prone world, the safety of citizens abroad has become a defining test of a nation’s diplomatic strength and governance. For India, home to one of the largest global diasporas, the challenge is both vast and urgent. Whether in West Asia, Europe, or Africa, Indian nationals frequently find themselves caught in volatile situations. In such moments, the role of the government becomes critical, not only in ensuring their safe return but also in reinforcing trust in the nation’s global outreach.

Under the leadership of Narendra Modi, India has demonstrated a more proactive, assertive, and citizen-centric foreign policy. Evacuating Indians from war zones has emerged as a key pillar of this approach, reflecting both humanitarian commitment and strategic capability.

India’s evolving foreign policy framework

India’s foreign policy has undergone a noticeable transformation in the past decade. Traditionally rooted in non-alignment, it has evolved into a model of “multi-alignment” and strategic autonomy. This approach allows India to maintain balanced relations with competing global powers while prioritising national interests.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has consistently emphasised that “the safety of every Indian, anywhere in the world, is the government’s top priority.” This philosophy has translated into swift and decisive evacuation missions during global crises. India’s diplomatic corps has been empowered to act quickly, negotiate effectively, and coordinate across multiple international stakeholders.

Lessons from recent evacuation missions

India’s recent evacuation efforts underscore its growing efficiency and global standing. Missions such as Operation Ganga, launched during the Russia-Ukraine conflict, successfully brought back thousands of Indian students stranded in war zones. The operation required coordination with Russia, Ukraine, and neighbouring European nations.

Similarly, Operation Devi Shakti highlighted India’s ability to act under extreme uncertainty following the Taliban takeover. Earlier, Operation Rahat showcased India’s capability to conduct large-scale sea evacuations, even assisting citizens from other countries.

These missions reflect a combination of political will, military readiness, and diplomatic finesse - elements that have been strengthened under the current leadership.

Modi doctrine: Citizen-first diplomacy

At the core of India’s evacuation strategy lies what many analysts describe as the “citizen-first” doctrine. This approach prioritises the welfare of Indian nationals above all else, regardless of geopolitical complexities.

Prime Minister Modi’s direct involvement in crisis situations has been a distinguishing feature. High-level monitoring, constant communication with foreign leaders, and real-time decision-making have enabled faster responses. The Ministry of External Affairs, backed by Indian embassies worldwide, plays a central role in executing these directives.

This approach also aligns with India’s broader vision of being a “Vishwaguru” (global leader), where humanitarian responsibility goes hand in hand with strategic interests.

Diplomatic strength and strategic neutrality

India’s ability to evacuate its citizens from war zones is deeply linked to its diplomatic positioning. By maintaining balanced relations with conflicting nations, India often gains access to safe corridors and logistical support.

For instance, during Operation Ganga, India managed to engage constructively with both Russia and Ukraine despite global polarisation. This was possible due to its policy of strategic neutrality, refusing to take rigid sides while advocating dialogue and peace. India’s engagement with global institutions such as the United Nations further strengthens its diplomatic leverage. By promoting peaceful resolutions and humanitarian aid, India builds goodwill that proves crucial during evacuation efforts.

Role of armed forces and logistics

India’s evacuation capabilities are heavily supported by its armed forces. The Indian Air Force has played a pivotal role in airlifting citizens from conflict zones, while the Indian Navy has ensured safe sea routes in high-risk regions.

In addition, partnerships with countries such as Poland, Romania, and Hungary have enabled the establishment of transit hubs, making evacuations more efficient. The use of commercial airlines, special flights, and coordinated land transport reflects a multi-layered logistical strategy that is continuously evolving.

The Modi government has increasingly leveraged technology to enhance crisis response. Digital platforms, real-time tracking systems, and social media have become essential tools for communication and coordination.

Citizens stranded abroad can now access helplines, register their locations, and receive updates instantly. This reduces confusion and ensures better management of large-scale evacuations.

However, greater awareness is needed among citizens to utilise these platforms effectively. Registration with embassies remains a crucial yet underutilised step.

Challenges that persist

Despite significant progress, challenges remain. War zones are inherently unpredictable, with risks such as sudden escalations, infrastructure collapse, and restricted access routes. Language barriers, lack of documentation, and misinformation can further complicate evacuation efforts. Additionally, coordinating between multiple agencies, both domestic and international, requires seamless integration, which is not always easy. Financial and logistical constraints also play a role, especially in prolonged conflicts where repeated evacuation efforts may be needed.

The road ahead

To further strengthen its evacuation framework, India must focus on institutionalising its crisis response mechanisms. A dedicated evacuation task force, regular simulation drills, and stronger international partnerships can enhance preparedness.

Public awareness campaigns should encourage Indians travelling abroad to register with embassies and follow official advisories. Investment in advanced technology and infrastructure will also be key to improving response times. Moreover, India can expand its humanitarian role by assisting other nations during crises, thereby reinforcing its global leadership credentials.

Conclusion

In today’s uncertain world, the ability to protect citizens beyond national borders is a hallmark of effective governance. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has taken significant strides in this direction, combining diplomatic strength with operational efficiency.

Evacuation missions are more than logistical exercises; they are a reflection of a nation’s commitment to its people. As India continues to rise on the global stage, its “citizen-first” foreign policy will remain central to its identity, ensuring that no Indian is left behind, even in the most challenging circumstances.

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AI is a double-edge sword, its use must be judicious



VISHAL
MISHRA

In an era where artificial intelligence is reshaping industries at an unprecedented pace, public relations is no exception. From content creation to media monitoring and audience targeting, AI is redefining how communication strategies are built and executed. Today, PR professionals are leveraging AI-powered tools to analyse large volumes of data, track real-time media sentiment, and identify emerging trends with greater accuracy. AI has also made content creation easier, ensuring faster creation of press releases, reports, and social media updates, all the while keeping the process consistent and efficient. Moreover, the use of analytics makes audience segmentation easier, thus ensuring that personalised messages are delivered to the target audience.

Nevertheless, although AI makes the process quicker and more accurate, it is the human aspect of creativity and critical thinking that still forms the basis of public relations. The future of public relations will depend on finding the perfect balance between technology and humanity.

Role of AI in PR strategy today

AI is rapidly becoming a core pillar of PR strategy. It helps professionals analyse audience behaviour, predict trends, and craft more targeted communication. What earlier took days — media monitoring, sentiment analysis, or data compilation — can now be done in minutes. This allows PR professionals to focus more on strategy, creativity, and relationship-building rather than just execution.

True nature and power of AI

AI is a powerful tool — neutral in itself — but its impact depends entirely on how it is used. It is like an AK-47 or atomic power; both can be used for protection and development or can cause massive destruction if misused. Similarly, AI can drive innovation, efficiency, and growth, but irresponsible use can lead to serious consequences, especially in influencing public perception.

AI can benefit PR and marketing

AI is a great equaliser. Small businesses, which earlier struggled with limited budgets, can now create high-quality content, targeted campaigns, and impactful videos using AI tools. With the right storytelling and visuals,



even a small entrepreneur can build a strong digital presence and compete with larger brands. It democratises access to professional-grade communication.

AI can play an important role in content writing for PR professionals

AI can be a valuable assistant in content creation. PR professionals can take help from AI to gather information, generate ideas, and even draft initial versions of content. However, one should never be fully dependent on it. Human judgement, creativity, and contextual understanding are irreplaceable. In fact, AI itself often suggests verifying information before using it. Therefore, validation, fact-checking, and personalisation by the PR professional remain essential to ensure credibility and authenticity.

Challenges that AI brings to the PR industry

The biggest challenge is the rise of fake news and misinformation. AI has given it a new level of sophistication — deepfakes, manipulated videos, and highly convincing false narratives. This can damage reputations, create panic, and even destabilise communities or countries. PR professionals now have an added responsibility to verify information and maintain credibility.

Adapting to this AI-driven landscape

PR professionals must evolve by embracing AI tools while strengthening ethical standards. Fact-checking, transparency, and authenticity will become even more critical. At the same time, professionals need to upskill — understanding how AI works, how to use it effectively, and where to draw the line.

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RBI REBOUNDS



After a series of destructive, aggressive, and unexpected moves to curb speculation and manipulation in the rupee, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) may take several constructive steps today. As it announces another round of monetary policy, experts contend that the central bank will aim to boost the foreign exchange reserves, which are hit by huge outflows from equities, and other assets, high trade deficits, and strong dollar. One of the major moves may include incentives to push non-residents to remit more money to India. In the recent past, according to media reports, non-resident deposits declined by a fourth to just over \$14 billion in the first 10 months of the last financial year (2025-26). The worst hit was one of the schemes, FCNR(B), where the fall was huge, from \$7 billion to less than a billion dollars in the same period. It is this scheme which may be in focus today.

Economists contend that the RBI has little options but to “engineer more sustainable inflows to mitigate depreciation pressure, and accommodate a higher fuel import bill” due to the war crisis in the Middle East. Like it did with the massive curbs on short selling positions in the rupee after nearly 15 years, the non-resident deposit schemes may see a few changes like what happened in 2013. According to a media report, “In 2013, post the taper-tantrum episode, the RBI for the first time launched a special swap window to attract... deposits to stem excessive volatility in the rupee, and prevent further fall in forex reserves. Banks were allowed to swap US dollar deposits, with a maturity of three years or more, at a concessional rate of 3.5 per cent, which was much cheaper than the market rate. This resulted in nearly \$30 billion in inflows, which helped stabilise the currency.”

Such swap windows may be reintroduced this time. Although the rupee has strengthened due to the excessive curbs on its speculation over the past few days, which include extreme limits on short positions, the central bank seems unsure about the currency’s journey. Even now, analysts predict the rupee to breach ₹95 to a dollar, as it did in the recent past, which shocked the RBI, and possibly proceed towards ₹100. Speculators, sensing huge opportunities to hammer down the currency, are waiting in the wings to launch fresh attacks. The psychological barrier of ₹95 or ₹100 is something that the Indian regulators and policy-makers wish to protect. It is not that they do not want the rupee to weaken. They wish this to happen slowly and steadily, maybe over a period of 12-18 months, and not in a stampede. The swap will offer banks with lucrative opportunities, even as they incurred high losses due to the destructive actions of the RBI.

Apart from the incentives, the central bank is unlikely to interfere much with the monetary policies, and adopt a further wait-and-watch attitude. Most experts feel that the interest rates will remain unchanged, although the future estimates for GDP growth will be reduced, and those for inflation will be enhanced. This is in line with the normal expectations that growth will stutter as the Iran war drags on, and restricted imports and exports, which impact manufacturing, services, and agriculture, will stunt growth. Prices will rise, as they have over the past 5-6 weeks, especially driven by fuel prices and shortages, which have a multiplier impact on inflation. For example, while the market price for liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) was raised, the cylinders are in shortage, and consumers in urban areas pay three times the market price to buy one. This forced migrants in the cities to go back to the villages, where alternate fuel sources are available, and costs of living are cheaper, despite the loss of incomes.

According to an economist quoted in a media report, “In the context of the stagflationary shock, and exogenous nature of the event risk, we expect the RBI to keep rates on hold... while addressing specific pockets of strain. We expect a change in the policy stance towards tightness if there are material spillover risks on core inflation, and potential second-round effects.” According to another one, “The RBI will remain vigilant and hold rates steady for the time being, without changing its stance from neutral.... There might be a chance of rate hike... (by) end-2027.” If the current account deficits remain high, and capital outflows continue, they may “pave the way for a third consecutive balance of payments deficit in FY 27 (after FY25 and FY26), which will be a first for the Indian economy. The central bank will keep this in mind, as it gingerly moves forward on the monetary policy path.

A few economists warn of a possible dire scenario. “Linear sensitivities from the past oil shocks are likely to underestimate the growth hit. If this persists, it may start to resemble the pandemic more than the 2022 (Russia-Ukraine-led) oil shock,” says one of them. The regulators and policy-makers may need to combine strategies, and go on a different form of a war-footing, akin to what they admirably did during the pandemic in 2020-21. The ongoing shocks may be unlike normal knocks.

Gen Z drives crypto urge, surge

Youngsters from North-East account for a third of retail investors

Despite the lack of clarity, adequate laws, and regulators’ concerns, India continues to rank among the top nations in terms of cryptocurrency adoption. More importantly, the investment momentum is shifting from the metros and cities to the rural and semi-urban markets. Even more interesting is the fact that the small investors from the North-Eastern states such as Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, and Meghalaya are driving the craze, urge, surge, and desires. Youngsters, especially those from Gen Z generation, dominate crypto trading. Clearly, crypto is throwing up cryptic conclusions.

Let us start with the Gen Z puzzle. According to a recent report, which analyses the trading of more than 2,00,000 crypto futures traders between January and December 2025, more than 60 per cent of the new traders are in the young 18-25 age bracket. Surprisingly, female participation rose by 20 per cent year-on-year, and women now account for roughly one in eight traders on the Pi42 platform, whose traders were part of the study. “This is no longer a niche phenomenon,” says Tak Lee, CEO & managing partner, Hashed Emergent, which prepared the report, India Web3 Landscape, based on the data.

The youngsters are more active, and trade more frequently. Thus, the trading frequency has surged, and close to 60 per cent of the active users trade daily, a number that went up by a third from 45 per cent earlier. In addition, nearly one in four traders reported profits, which indicates that the savvy and smart youngsters are aware of the investment strategies, and risk management. This is unlike recent reports that found that the majority of derivatives (stock) traders incur huge losses. Since the crypto triptoes, or traders, make money, they are ultra-confident. Hence, the average trade size has nearly doubled from \$1,051 in 2024 to \$1,960 in 2025, which hints at conviction-led tactics.

“These trends signal a clear shift in how Indian investors are engaging with crypto derivatives.

Even amid ongoing global macro and geopolitical uncertainties, trading activity on the platform has remained resilient, with investors continuing to increase participation, trade sizes, and overall conviction,” says Avinash Shekhar, co-founder & CEO, Pi42. Unlike stocks, where the technicalities seem to confound the investors, including the younger ones, the world of cryptic crypto seems to energise them. Or one can conclude that making money is more difficult in the volatile stock markets, compared to crypto exchanges, where the volatility is steep but less regular.

North-East India has emerged as the fastest-growing region, and now contributes almost a third of retail investors. States such as Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, and Meghalaya lead the trend. It seems surprising that these states, rather than the traditionally-savvy financial states such as Gujarat, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, and even Tamil Nadu, and Karnataka lag. The outperformance of the North-East may, however, be attributed to several factors. For example, these states have lower penetration of traditional financial products. Hence, crypto offers a first-time, and primary entry point for investments.

Real estate and gold traditionally dominate most regions across the nation, but crypto offers a low-entry, high-liquidity alternative, which is accessible without the intermediaries, who are largely absent or on the lower side in the North-East. In many of these states, there are few and limited number of local wealth managers or brokerage ecosystems. A high proportion of the literate, English-speaking, young, and mobile-first users in the region accelerates the adoption to cryptos, even as Internet access and affordable data expands participation. One can possibly contend that entry barriers in crypto are low.

No one can dispute that the returns from cryptos are higher than other assets, especially

stocks. In the past four years, the Sensex gained less than 50 per cent. In comparison, Bitcoin, which ruled below \$20,000 went up 6x to a high of \$1,20,000, and has now settled at \$70,000. In addition, unlike the regular volatility in the stock exchange indices, Bitcoin has seen three massive surges and falls, all of them scary, but hugely profitable if one had the patience and nerves. The risks are high, so are the returns, and Gen Z from the North-East like it.

However, experts warn that this may lead to an imbalance between risks and returns. “Crypto assets are risky, and often extremely volatile, meaning that price swings can be dramatic and unpredictable, leading to a significant risk of losing all your investment.

Additionally, investing in crypto requires careful consideration of asset allocation and diversification to manage these risks,” states an AI-generated query. To put this in perspective, in the recent past, Bitcoin has dropped from \$1,20,000 to \$70,000. In addition, most of Gen Z, across cities, may be more invested in crypto, and do not believe in a balanced portfolio.

Apart from the regional skew, there is a strong change in similar skews within urban cities, and between urban and rural areas. There is a renewed interest in cryptos in Tier 2 and Tier 3 towns. Strong community-led adoption through peer networks, and social channels amplify growth. Today, government-led initiatives, such as affordable smartphones and low-cost data (thanks to players like Reliance Jio), dramatically improve Internet access in such towns, which enables participation in high-frequency products like crypto futures. Limited access to local investment avenues, and a higher risk appetite among the first-time young investors pushes for greater participation.

These regional and city disparities underscore a broader shift that crypto futures trading is no longer metro-centric, but is rapidly gaining traction across emerging parts of the country. “Derivatives are becoming the entry point for a new generation of digitally native investors, and the data suggests that we are still in the early innings of this adoption curve,” says Lee. “We are seeing young, digitally native users adopt more strategic and informed trading approaches, while adoption from emerging regions is accelerating at a strong pace. This momentum reflects a structurally expanding market where derivatives platforms can play a meaningful role in improving accessibility, enabling wider participation, and supporting the long-term growth of India’s digital asset ecosystem,” says Shekhar.

However, one needs to put in a caveat. If the increased interest in crypto is due to mobile-first generation, Internet access, low data costs, low entry barriers, and high return potential, we need to be careful. Global studies show that such factors contribute greatly to the use of social media to disseminate information about the cryptos. While this enthruses the youngsters, and for obvious reasons, it embeds a potential for misinformation, and “potentially harming investment strategies.”

OUR TAKE



CHITRA SARUPARIA

In India, caring for the aging parents has long been seen as a natural extension of family responsibility. In recent years, however, this expectation is increasingly being reinforced by legal and policy measures. The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007, allows the elderly to claim maintenance from children through special tribunals. This converts what was once primarily a moral-personal-family obligation into a legally enforceable one. Recent developments, such as the Telangana Employees Accountability and Monitoring of Parental Support Bill, 2026, proposes the linking of parental care obligations with employment responsibilities. The law further intensifies the discussions and debates on elderly care.

Other States have introduced schemes that are aimed at improving the well-being of the senior citizens. Kerala’s Vayomithram initiative, for example, provides community-based support, which includes health check-ups, counseling, and social interaction through the local Governments. Tamil Nadu expanded the old-age pension schemes, and operates state-supported homes for the elderly citizens who lack family care. In Delhi, mobile medical units and home-based healthcare services improve access to healthcare for older residents. Similarly, the welfare departments in Karnataka and Maharashtra run old-age homes, and provide financial assistance schemes for the senior citizens.

These initiatives suggest that the issues related to the elderly care are gradually being recognised as all-encompassing ones. Moving beyond the personal and family, they are seen as enveloping the State, and markets, apart from families. The umbrella law establishes the children’s responsibility to support their aging parents. Markets are slowly expanding services such as assisted living facilities, home care providers, and geriatric health services. Despite these developments, and laws and schemes across several states, the everyday work of caregiving continues to be largely carried out within families.

Within the households, however, caregiving duties are rarely shared equally. Elderly care involves assisting with mobility, managing medication, arranging medical consultations, and providing emotional support. These tasks demand time, attention, and physical effort, apart from a sense of moral, emotional, and human obligations. In practice, not surprisingly, most of these works are often carried out by women. In modern families, men do contribute, and many male chil-

Who really cares for the elderly?

Looking after older people needs efforts by State, markets, families



dren do assist, but they do so more in terms of financial help, rather than time and effort. Hence, there are feminist issues involved.

Feminist economists have long emphasised that unpaid care work forms an essential but largely invisible component of economic life. (This is, in fact, true for most of the household and family work by women, which is not considered as work.) Nancy Folbre describes caregiving as part of the “care economy,” a sphere of labour that sustains families and societies, but remains undervalued in economic policy. Similarly, Diane Elson argues that economic systems rely heavily on unpaid household labor, much of it performed by women. However, new studies aim to compute the contributions in terms of productivity and GDP.

Evidence from India reflects this reality. According to the National Statistical Office’s Time Use Survey, women devote substantially more time to caregiving than men. Women spend around 140 minutes per day on caregiving activities, including care for the elderly household members, while men spend almost half the time, about 74 minutes. Participation in caregiving reveals a significant disparity. More than 40 per cent of the women engage in such crucial and sensitive activities, and the involvement of the men is

almost half, about 21 per cent.

These figures indicate that while the laws mandate family responsibility for elderly care, the labour involved is disproportionately borne by the women. Systems of family-based care frequently depend on women’s unpaid time. This unequal distribution creates what the economists dub as time poverty. Hours spent on unpaid care reduce the time available for paid employment, education, and skill development. As a result, caregiving duties influence women’s economic opportunities, and participation in the labour force. The fact remains that the latter figure is quite low in India, and abysmally low in several states, although some improvements were observed.

As India’s population continues to age, the demand for elderly care is likely to grow significantly. If institutional support systems remain limited, families will continue to provide most of this care, and women within the households will bear a large share of the burden. Addressing these challenges requires a recognition that elderly care cannot remain solely a private family responsibility. A sustainable system must distribute responsibility more clearly among the State, markets, and families, while ensuring that the care work within the households is shared more equally between

men and women. The State must strengthen the social support systems for the elderly. Expanding social pensions, investing in community-based elder care centres, and improving home-based healthcare services can reduce the caregiving burden placed on families. Public investment in geriatric care infrastructure will help to ensure that elderly citizens receive reliable support. The market can complement these efforts by developing professional care services. There is gradual and noticeable growth in assisted living facilities, trained caregivers, and home nursing services. With laws and quality standards, they can provide families with alternatives to relying solely on unpaid household labour.

Of course, there is no doubt that families will continue to remain an important source of emotional and social support for the elderly. But the growing demand for care makes it essential to reconsider how caregiving is distributed within the households. As the State ensures the higher involvement of the markets, men need to take initiatives to play a greater role so that the burden does not fall disproportionately on the women. This mindset requires changes at homes and workplaces. Workplace institutions can initiate far-reaching policies such as caregiver leaves, flexible work arrangements, and supportive practices.

Laws do help, as they mandate the families and markets to care for the elderly parents. But without the institutional support, and more equal sharing of caregiving within the households, the burden will be shared unevenly, both within the families, and by the State and markets. The truth is that the country’s demographic dividends are about to change over the next two decades, and the percentage of the elderly will rise. Hence, ensuring dignified aging in India requires a recognition that care work will emerge as an essential part of the economy. Thus, there is a need to create future-looking systems and institutions that can enable the State and markets to intervene efficiently and effectively, and make it easier for family members to distribute responsibilities more fairly. The time to act is now, over the next few years.

(The writer is Associate Professor (Economics), and Director, National Law University, Jodhpur)

Air India hikes airfare for domestic flights after CEO resigns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai/New Delhi

On a day the Tata Group-owned Air India announced that its CEO and MD Campbell Wilson has resigned and the airline has set up a committee to find his successor, the airline on Tuesday also hiked the airfares for domestic flights due to the ongoing West Asia conflict. Indigo was the first airline to increase the fares.

The revised Air India fares are distance-based, replacing the earlier flat charge. This means the extra amount a passenger pays will now depend on how far they are flying. For short-haul flights of up to 500 km, passengers will

pay an additional ₹299. For routes between 501 km and 1,000 km, the surcharge has been set at ₹399.

Flights covering 1,001 km to 1,500 km will attract a surcharge of ₹549.

For longer domestic routes between 1,501 km and 2,000 km, passengers will pay ₹ 749. For flights above 2,000 km, the surcharge goes up to ₹899, which is the highest among domestic categories. These revised charges will come into effect from 9:01 am IST on April 8.

As regards the shake-up at the top level in the airlines, Wilson, a native of New Zealand and a former Singapore Airlines' veteran, has been at the helm of the



airline for four years as Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director. "Wilson had conveyed his intention to step down in 2026 to Air India Chairman N

Chandrasekaran in 2024 and, since then, has been working to ensure the organisation and leadership team are on a stable footing for the transition," the airline said in a statement. The Air India board has constituted a committee that will find the successor in the coming months, it said.

Wilson, who took the reins of the airline in September 2022 following the privatisation of the then government-owned carrier, will continue in the position till his successor is announced, the statement added.

Wilson had been under fire following the crash of the airline's London-bound flight in Ahmedabad on June 12,

which killed over 250 people, and also for alleged violations of safety norms on various other occasions.

Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran appreciated the contribution of Wilson and said under his leadership Air India made progress on several fronts. "...it is also worth acknowledging the numerous external challenges navigated by the Air India team, including prolonged post-Covid supply chain constraints that have impacted delivery of new aircraft and retrofit programmes as well as major geopolitical and other headwinds," he said.

Wilson said, "The four years since Air India's privatisation

has seen the acquisition and successful merger of four airlines, an evolution from public to private sector practices along with renewal of the leadership team, workforce, culture and ways of operating." Air India has seen the complete modernisation of systems, the launch of new physical products, and deployment of elevated service standards on ground and in the air, as well as 100 additional aircraft added to the fleet, he added.

Air India's low-cost subsidiary, Air India Express, also does not have a head since March 19 this year following the exit of then Managing Director Aloke after he completed his 5-year tenure.

Chouhan calls for increasing productivity, raising farmers' income

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Tuesday said food security is of paramount importance and called for increasing productivity, reducing the cost of production and ensuring remunerative prices so that farmers earn reasonable profits.

Addressing the Western Zonal Agriculture Conference, Chouhan said India should not only meet its domestic needs but also contribute to global food requirements. "Food security is of paramount importance. In the present global situation, dependence on other countries for food is unacceptable. We must



become self-reliant. In wheat and rice, we have made significant progress, and our stocks are full. We also need to become self-sufficient in pulses and oilseeds," he said.

He stressed that diversification of agriculture, adoption of new scientific farming techniques and natural farming are needed to raise farmers' income and keep the soil healthy for future generations.

On raising farmers' income, he said serving farmers is like serving God, as agriculture provides livelihood to nearly half the country's population. The Minister pointed to the challenges posed by climate change, including unseasonal rains and extreme weather events that damage crops. He said diversification of farming, adoption of integrated farming models, hydroponics and other new techniques are important to make farming profitable

even on small landholdings. "We have developed models of integrated farming which go beyond just growing grains. These models will be popularised among farmers so that they can increase their income by taking up multiple activities," he said.

Chouhan voiced concern over declining soil fertility due to excessive use of chemical fertilisers and pesticides and called for the promotion of natural farming to preserve the earth for the coming generations.

He urged States to implement central schemes effectively, assess crop losses due to recent rainfall properly so that farmers get full benefits under the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana, and take up Farmer ID work on a

mission mode. Referring to the new budget, he said States have been given flexibility to allocate more funds to schemes that are particularly useful for their regions.

The Centre has decided to hold five regional conferences across the country, taking into account diverse climate zones, for detailed discussions on agriculture-related issues. The first conference began in Jaipur on Tuesday. Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma also addressed the inaugural ceremony.

Agriculture ministers and officers from Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Goa and Maharashtra, progressive farmers, and agriculture experts are participating in the conference.

India, New Zealand FTA likely to be signed on April 24



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India and New Zealand are expected to sign a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) on April 24, which will provide tariff-free access to domestic exporters for their goods in the island nation's market, and will bring in \$20 billion of investment over the next 15 years, an official said.

cheese; onions, sugar, spices, edible oils and rubber to protect farmers and domestic industry.

Under the pact, New Zealand will also get duty-free access to goods such as sheep meat, wool, coal and over 95 per cent of forestry and wood articles.

As regards the services sector, New Zealand will give a temporary employment entry visa pathway for Indian professionals in skilled occupations with a quota of 5,000 visas annually and a stay of up to three years.

The two countries, on December 22 last year, announced the conclusion of negotiations for the trade deal, which aims at doubling bilateral trade to \$5 billion in the next five years.

The official said that the pact is likely to be signed on April 24 in Bharat Mandapam.

While India will get zero-duty market access on 100 per cent of its exports, the agreement will eliminate or reduce tariffs on 95 per cent of New Zealand's exports to India, including items ranging from wool, coal, wood, wine, to avocados and blueberries. However, New Delhi has made no duty concessions on allowing imports of dairy like milk, cream, whey, yoghurt, and

This pathway covers Indian professions such as AYUSH practitioners, yoga instructors, Indian chefs, and music teachers, as well as high-demand sectors including IT, engineering, healthcare, education, and construction, strengthening workforce mobility and services trade.

Bilateral merchandise trade stood at \$1.3 billion in 2024-25. The total trade in goods and services reached about \$2.4 billion in 2024, with services trade alone reaching \$1.24 billion, led by travel, IT, and business services.

Crude oil futures hit record high of ₹10,888/barrel



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices rose nearly 3 per cent to hit a record high of ₹10,888 per barrel in futures trade on Tuesday, tracking strong global cues as tensions between the US and Iran intensified ahead of President Donald Trump's deadline for reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), crude oil for April delivery increased by ₹300, or 2.83 per cent, to hit a lifetime high of ₹10,888 per barrel. Similarly, the May contract also advanced ₹170, or 1.82 per cent, to touch a fresh record high of ₹9,485 per barrel on the MCX.

"Crude oil prices remained firm as geopolitical tensions intensified ahead of US President Donald Trump's deadline for Iran, keeping markets highly sensitive to every development surrounding the Strait of Hormuz," Kaveri More, Commodity Analyst at Choice Broking, said.

Threats of potential strikes on Iranian infrastructure and warnings from Tehran of retaliation against Gulf

energy assets have heightened fears of supply disruptions, overshadowing diplomatic efforts toward a ceasefire, she added.

"With the Strait of Hormuz being a critical route for global oil flows, uncertainty continues to fuel volatility, while rising inflation expectations and a stronger US dollar index above 100 reflect broader macroeconomic concerns tied closely to energy prices," More said.

In the international market, West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude futures for the May delivery gained \$ 4.14, or 3.7 per cent to \$116.55 per barrel, while Brent oil for the June contract rose 1.5 per cent to \$111.40 per barrel in New York.

"WTI crude futures climbed toward \$115 per barrel, trading near their highest close since June 2022 as President Trump's deadline for Iran to strike a deal or face intensified attacks approached," Jigar Trivedi, Senior Research Analyst at IndusInd Securities, said. Meanwhile, Trump on Monday reiterated threats to strike Iranian power plants and other civilian infrastructure.

EV retail sales up 24.6 pc in FY26: FADA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Total electric vehicle retail sales in India grew by 24.6 per cent at 24.52 lakh units in FY26 as compared to the previous fiscal, with every category delivering strong double-digit growth, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations said on Tuesday.

While electric two-wheelers crossed 14 lakh units, electric passenger vehicle retail sales missed the 2 lakh units by a whisker but surged 83.63 per cent in FY26, FADA said in a statement. "FY'26 has been a watershed year for India's electric mobility story. Total EV retail across two-wheel-



ers, three-wheelers, passenger vehicles, and commercial vehicles stood at approximately 24.52 lakh units, growing nearly 24.6 per cent YoY, with every category delivering strong double-digit growth," FADA President CS Vigneshwar said. In the electric PV category, total sales were at 1,99,923 units in FY26 as

respectively, as per FADA data. The electric two-wheeler category saw a growth of 21.81 per cent at 14,01,818 units in FY26, up from 11,50,790 units in FY25.

TVS Motor Company was the leader in the segment with 3,41,513 units, followed by Bajaj Auto with 2,89,349 units in second place and Ather Energy with 2,39,178 units in the third spot in FY26. FADA said the electric three-wheeler category witnessed a growth of 18.97 per cent at 8,30,819 units in FY26 as compared to 6,98,914 units in FY25.

Electric commercial vehicle sales zoomed 120.57 per cent at 19,454 units in FY26 as compared to 8820 units in FY25, FADA said.

Govt mulling options to retain 51% stake in PFC post-merger with REC: Official

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government is looking at options, including issuance of preference shares or fresh equity, to maintain 51 per cent stake in the State-owned Power Finance Corporation (PFC) post its merger with Rural Electrification Corporation (REC), a senior official said.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had, in the FY27 Budget, announced the restructuring of PFC and REC to help achieve scale and improve efficiency in the public sector NBFC space. "The Government would like to retain a majority stake in the merged entity as it would

be the largest Government-owned NBFC with strategic presence. Discussions are going on over the options to ensure that the Government stake in the merged entity does not fall below 51 per cent," the official said.

As per the Companies Act, a "Government company" is one in which not less than 51 per cent of the paid-up share capital is held by the Central Government, or by any State Government, and includes a company that is a subsidiary company of such a Government company.

One of the options being discussed is the issuance of preference shares by PFC to the promoter, which is the Government. The other



option on the table is the issuance of fresh equity to the Government. Both options will help the government increase its stake in PFC so that the merged entity remains a State-owned company, the official told

FINANCE MINISTER NIRMALA SITHARAMAN HAD, IN THE FY27 BUDGET, ANNOUNCED THE RESTRUCTURING OF PFC AND REC TO IMPROVE EFFICIENCY

piece, while REC shares were trading at ₹329.05 on the BSE on Tuesday.

The merged entity, officials said, would have a larger underwriting capacity for big-ticket projects and enhanced risk absorption appetite. It would enhance the scope for portfolio diversification in sectors like

renewables and transmission, and better compete with peers. The Companies Act stipulates that a "Government company" must have at least 51 per cent of its stake held by the central or State Government.

As of December 31, 2025, PFC's consolidated loan asset book was ₹11.51 lakh crore, while REC's loan asset book was ₹5.82 lakh crore. Under the administrative control of the power ministry, PFC finances projects related to the power sector and holds 20 per cent market share. REC finances power sector projects involved in generation, transmission, distribution, renewable energy, and new technologies.

Gold futures decline to ₹1.49 lakh/10g as oil surges

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Gold prices declined by ₹610 to ₹1.49 lakh per 10 grams in futures trade on Tuesday as surging crude oil rates and escalating tensions in West Asia dampened the demand for the safe-haven asset and kept investors cautious.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the yellow metal for June delivery depreciated by ₹610, or 0.41 per cent, to ₹1,49,371 per 10 grams in a business turnover of 7,270 lots. Gold traded slightly lower on Tuesday as crude oil climbed towards \$115 per barrel amid heightened geopolitical tensions particularly in the West Asia, Gaurav Garg, and Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk. The surge in energy



prices have created a risk-off sentiment among investors, leading to cautious trading in gold, even as it remain range-bound with a slight upward bias anticipated, he added.

In the international market, Comex gold futures for the June contract fell \$19.13, or 0.41 per cent, to \$4,665.57 per ounce in New York.

Gold is trading in a narrow range for two consecutive

Hormuz, warning of strikes on power plants and other civilian infrastructure.

Tehran rejected the demand and continued attacks on regional energy assets, although diplomatic channels remain active, with reports suggesting discussions around a 45-day ceasefire framework.

Rising crude oil prices have also heightened concerns that inflation could resurface potentially pushing major global central banks, including the US Federal Reserve, to approach a more hawkish stance, Chainani said. Investors are now awaiting US GDP numbers and the Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC) meeting minutes later this week for further direction on bullion prices, she added.

Govt plans ₹2.5 lakh cr credit guarantee scheme for businesses affected by West Asia crisis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government is considering a ₹2.5 lakh crore credit guarantee scheme to support businesses, especially MSMEs impacted by the West Asia crisis, sources said.

Under the scheme, a credit guarantee of about 90 per cent on loans of up to ₹100 crore would be provided to lenders in case of default by borrowers due to the ongoing US-Iran conflict.

The guarantee on bank loans would be provided by the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (NCGTC), a wholly-owned subsidiary of the Government. The Government would have to

provide about ₹17,000 crore to ₹18,000 crore for the scheme. Sources said the scheme was a huge success during the COVID-19 pandemic and helped many businesses across various sectors to stay afloat and clear their dues.

The Government in May 2020 announced the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS) as part of the Aatmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyaan to support eligible Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) and other eligible business enterprises in meeting their operational liabilities and restarting their businesses in the context of the disruption caused by the COVID-19 pandemic.



ECLGS covered almost all the sectors of the economy, and a 100 per cent guarantee was provided to Member Lending Institutions (MLIs) in respect of the credit facility extended by them under the scheme to eligible borrowers. The structure of the scheme permitted easy access to credit as the lenders offer pre-approved loans based on the borrower's existing credit

outstanding, and there is no fresh appraisal undertaken by lenders since additional credit was sanctioned over and above the credit facilities already assessed.

Further, the interest rate was also capped with a view to lowering the cost of credit and loans are sanctioned without any processing charges, pre-payment charges and guarantee fees.

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

Nepal recalls six envoys

Nepal has recalled its ambassadors from six countries, including India, who were appointed by the previous KP Sharma Oli-led Government. The Government has recalled ambassadors serving in India, Australia, Sri Lanka, Denmark, South Korea and South Africa through a cabinet decision, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lok Bahadur Chhetri said. Those recalled include Shankar Prasad Sharma (India), Chitralekha Yadav (Australia), Sumnima Tuladhar (Denmark), Purna Bahadur Nepali (Sri Lanka), Shivamaya Tumbahamphe (South Korea) and Kapilman Shrestha (South Africa). According to the Foreign Ministry, letters have been issued on Monday directing the envoys to return within a month.

AUSTRALIA

Soldier charged with war crimes

A former Australian soldier was charged on Tuesday with war crimes on allegations that he killed five unarmed Afghans while serving in Afghanistan from 2009 to 2012, police said. Police have not confirmed the 47-year-old man's name. He is expected to appear in a Sydney court later on Tuesday. The soldier is only the second Australian veteran of the Afghanistan campaign to be charged with a war crime. Former Special Air Service Regiment soldier Oliver Schulz, 44, has pleaded not guilty to a charge of war crime murder. He is accused of shooting Afghan man Dad Mohammad three times in the head in an Uruzgan province wheatfield in May 2012. War crime murder carries a potential sentence of life in prison. It's a federal crime in Australia, defined as the intentional killing in the context of armed conflict of a person who is not taking an active part in hostilities.

Gunmen attack building housing Israeli Consulate in Istanbul

KHALIL HAMRA/SUZAN FRASER
■ Istanbul

Three assailants opened fire at police outside a building housing the Israeli Consulate in Istanbul on Tuesday, sparking a gunfight that left one attacker dead, Turkish officials said. The two other assailants were wounded and captured.

Two police officers sustained slight injuries in the clash, Istanbul Gov. Davut Gul told reporters. The assailants were carrying long-barrelled weapons. Interior Minister Mustafa Cifti wrote on X that the attackers had travelled from the city of Izmit, some 100 kilometres east of Istanbul,

Crushing Iranian regime, attack not against its people: Netanyahu



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jerusalem

Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Tuesday said that his country is "crushing the regime in Iran with great vigour" while asserting that the Israeli offensive against Tehran is not against its people.

"I tell you constantly that we are crushing the terrorist regime in Iran. But we are doing so with even greater vigour, and with increasing force," Netanyahu said as the world waited with bated breath for the approaching deadline issued by US President Donald Trump.

"Yesterday, our pilots destroyed transport planes and dozens of helicopters at an Iranian Air Force base.

Today, they attacked the train tracks and bridges used by the Revolutionary Guards. They use these to transport raw materials for weapons, and the operatives who attack us, the US, and the countries of the region, the same operatives who also oppress the Iranian people," Netanyahu said.



Turkish police secure the area after a gunman attack at a building housing the Israeli Consulate in Turkey

AP

Russia, China veto UN plan on Strait of Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ United Nations

Russia and China on Tuesday vetoed a UN Security Council resolution aimed at reopening the Strait of Hormuz that had been repeatedly watered down in hopes those two countries would abstain.

The vote — 11 in favour, two against and two abstentions — took place just hours before an 8 pm Eastern deadline set by US President Donald Trump for Iran to open the strategic waterway or face attacks on its power plants and bridges. One-fifth of the world's oil typically passes through the strait, and Iran's stranglehold during the war has sent energy prices soaring.

It's doubtful the resolution, even if it had been adopted, would have impacted the war, now in its fifth week, because it has been significantly weakened to try to get Russia and China to abstain rather than veto it.

The initial Bahrain proposal would have authorised countries to use "all necessary means" — UN wording that would include military action — to ensure transit through the Strait of Hormuz and deter attempts to close it.

After Russia, China and France, all veto-wielding countries on the 15-member Security Council, expressed opposition to approving the use of force, the resolution was revised to eliminate all references to offensive action. It would have authorised only "all defensive means necessary."

A vote had been expected on Saturday. But instead the resolution was further weakened to eliminate any reference to Security Council authorisation — which is an order for action — and limit its provisions to the Strait of Hormuz. Previous drafts had included adjacent waters.

The resolution vetoed Tuesday "strongly encourages states interested in the use of commercial maritime routes in the Strait of Hormuz to coordinate efforts, defensive in nature, commensurate with the circumstances, to contribute to ensuring the safety and security of navigation across the Strait of Hormuz."

This should include escorting merchant and commercial vessels, and deterring attempts to close, obstruct or interfere with international navigation through the strait, it says.



The resolution also demanded that Iran immediately halt attacks on merchant and commercial vessels and stop impeding their freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz and attacking civilian infrastructure.

In response to the US and Israeli attacks, Iran has targeted hotels, airports, residential buildings and other civilian infrastructure in more than 10 countries, including the Islamic Republic's Gulf neighbours, some of the world's major exporters of oil and natural gas.

Iran's blockade in the strait is seen by Gulf nations as an existential threat. Bahrain, a Gulf nation that hosts the US Fifth Fleet and is the Security Council's Arab representative and its president this month, has been pressing for UN action.

US strikes Kharg Island again, a critical oil hub for Iran

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The US again struck the Iranian oil hub of Kharg Island, according to a White House official who was not authorised to speak publicly and spoke on condition of anonymity.

The US hit military targets on the island, the official said Tuesday. The strikes came hours ahead of a deadline President Donald Trump set for Iran to capitulate to his demands or face a major attack. He said on Tuesday morning that "whole civilisation will die tonight" if Iran did not make a deal.

Trump has threatened to deploy ground troops to seize critical oil infrastructure on the island, but



experts warn such an operation would cost the lives of many US military members and would not be a decisive move to ending the war. The US had earlier in the

war struck several targets on the island, including air defences, a radar site, an airport and a hovercraft base, according to satellite analysis by the

Institute for the Study of War and American Enterprise Institute's Critical Threats Project.

Earlier Tuesday, the semi-official Mehr news agency

put out a report saying there had been several explosions on Kharg Island, without elaborating.

Saudi intercepts missile attacks

Saudi Arabia said early Tuesday that seven ballistic missiles from Iran targeted the kingdom's oil-rich Eastern Province, with "debris from the missiles" crashing into the ground near energy facilities.

The brief statement from Major General Turki al-Malki, a spokesman for the Saudi military, did not elaborate on the extent of the damage on the ground, though he said an "assessment is underway." It wasn't immediately clear what energies facilities had been impacted.

Iran has allowed two former French detainees to leave country, says Macron

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Paris

Iran has allowed former two French detainees, Cecile Kohler and Jacques Paris, to leave the country, French President Emmanuel Macron said Tuesday. They had been holed up in French diplomatic premises there since their release from prison.

"Cecile Kohler and Jacques Paris are free and on route toward French territory, after

three and a half years of detention in Iran," Macron posted on X. The green light for them to leave Iran, long sought by France, signalled how Iran is differentiating between nations, treating some favourably and others as foes, in the context of the Iran war. Macron has distanced France from the conflict, saying his country wasn't consulted in advance about the US-Israel strikes and didn't want the war. Macron thanked Oman for playing a mediation role in the release of Kohler and Paris. "It's a relief for us all and obviously for their families," Macron wrote. Iranian authorities freed them from prison in November but didn't let them leave the country. They'd been held for more than three years in detention on spying charges, which Paris said were unfounded.

Pak condemns attack on Saudi energy facilities

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Islamabad

Pakistan's top civil and military leadership on Tuesday condemned Iran's attacks on energy facilities in the eastern region of Saudi Arabia, calling it a "dangerous escalation" that undermines regional peace and stability.

The attack came as Pakistan was making last-ditch efforts to arrange a ceasefire between the US and Iran. "The Government of Pakistan expresses its deep concern and unequivocal condemnation of the missile and drone attacks carried out by the Islamic

Republic of Iran last night against energy facilities in the Eastern Region of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia," the Foreign Office said.

Separately, the Pakistan Army described the Iranian attack on Saudi energy facilities as "unnecessary escalation", which spoils sincere efforts to resolve the conflict through peaceful means.

In a statement issued after the Commanders' Conference at General Headquarters in Rawalpindi, chaired by Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir, the army said the generals undertook a review of the prevailing internal and external security environment.

80 migrants missing after boat capsizes off Libya coast: UN

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Cairo

More than 80 migrants went missing after a boat that departed a Libyan coastal town capsized in the central Mediterranean, the UN migration agency said Tuesday. The bodies of at least two of them have been recovered.

About 120 people were on board when the boat departed from the town of Tajoura in northwestern Libya on Sunday. The vessel later overturned after taking on water during harsh weather conditions, according to the International Organisation for Migration,



or IOM. A merchant vessel and a tugboat managed to save 32 people and the Italian coast guard transferred them to the southern Italian island of Lampedusa. Two bodies were also recovered, authorities said.

Libya has been a main transit point for migrants fleeing war and poverty in Africa and the Middle East.

The country plunged into chaos after a 2011 uprising toppled and killed longtime dictator Moammar Gadhafi.

The Sunday incident comes around a week after the Italian coast guard found 19 bodies and rescued 58 people when intercepting a dinghy filled with migrants about 80 nautical miles from Lampedusa. The tiny island of Lampedusa is the main entry point to Europe for migrants crossing the Mediterranean Sea from North Africa, with thousands dying during the perilous journey.

Most of the deaths have been attributed to small boats setting off from the coasts of Tunisia and Libya.

Heavy rains, floods kill 22 in Afghanistan

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kabul

Afghan authorities said on Tuesday that extreme weather has left 22 people dead and 32 injured over the last 24 hours, including more than a dozen who were killed when torrential rainfall caused the roofs of houses to collapse overnight in eastern Afghanistan.

Storms and heavy rainfall that have caused landslides, flooding and lightning strikes across the country over the past two

weeks have left more than 130 people dead and destroyed or damaged thousands of homes, authorities have said.

The latest casualty figures from the Afghanistan National Disaster Authority come on top of dozens of deaths caused by heavy snowfall and floods earlier this year in Afghanistan, an impoverished country that is highly vulnerable to extreme weather events. The authority said the figures could increase further.

Taiwan's opposition leader Cheng arrives in China on a journey of peace, to meet Xi

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing/Shanghai

A delegation of the pro-Beijing Chinese Kuomintang (KMT) party, led by its leader Cheng Li-wun, arrived in Shanghai on Tuesday on a six-day visit during which it is likely to meet President Xi Jinping to discuss easing of cross-strait tensions.

Cheng's visit to China, being closely watched around the world, marks the first trip by a KMT leader in a decade. The focus of her visit was expected to be a meeting with Xi, who, since



he assumed power in 2012, stepped up efforts to "re-unify" Taiwan, strictly enforcing its One-China policy, according to high military and diplomatic priority to it. China claims Taiwan as part of it and pledges to

reunite it with the mainland. China calls Taiwan's ruling Democratic Progressive Party (DPP) separatists and tacitly backs the pro-Beijing KMT as it advocates close ties with the mainland.

DPP firmly opposes China's attempts to reunify Taiwan with the mainland and advocates for the breakaway island to retain its identity. Speaking ahead of her departure to Beijing, Cheng called the visit a "journey of peace" and said both sides of the Taiwan Strait should seek dialogue and communica-

tion to resolve their differences. "It is undeniable that the current international environment is volatile, with conflict spreading and public anxiety rising," she said.

"The Taiwan Strait has long been regarded as one of the most dangerous places, so we must ensure that 'if the strait is safe, the world is safe'."

Cheng's visit is regarded as significant as it comes ahead of Donald Trump's trip to Beijing on May 14-15, during which Taiwan is expected to figure prominently in his talks with Xi. (PTI)

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-AUCTION NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/PS, Northern Railway Delhi Division invites bids through e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for the allotment of Deluxe Pay & Use Toilet Contracts on MOT Basis, at following Railway stations/Locations:

E-Catalogue No.	Date & Time of bidding	Railway Stations/Locations/Sites
PaynUse-3-2026	23.02.2026 at 12:00 hrs.	Hazrat Nizamuddin (NZM) 03 Sites, Delhi (DLI) 01 Site, Anand Vihar (ANVT) 01 Site & Panipat 01 Site (PNP) Total 6 Sites.

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen

<https://ireps.gov.in/>

All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids: • Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module •Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module • Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details. • A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism.

The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions. • Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender /E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.

Railway Authority to contact, in case of any query

Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055
E-Mail: sanitationcell@gmail.com
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SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Zelenskyy offers Easter pause on energy strikes

DEREK GATOPOULOS
■ Kyiv

Ukraine is proposing to Russia a pause in attacks on each other's energy infrastructure over the Orthodox Easter holiday, which will be observed this coming weekend, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

The offer was made through the United States, which has been mediating talks between delegations from Moscow and Kyiv, Zelenskyy said, as Russia's invasion stretches into a fifth year.

"If Russia is ready to stop strikes on our energy infrastructure, we will be ready to respond in kind," the Ukrainian leader said in a public address late Monday. "This proposal, conveyed through the Americans, has already been presented to the Russian side."

There was no immediate comment from Moscow about the proposal. Previous attempts to secure cease-fires have had little or no impact.

Russian President Vladimir Putin unilaterally declared a 30-hour ceasefire last Easter, but each side accused the other of breaking it. Russia effectively rejected a 30-day unconditional truce proposed last year by the US and Ukraine as a step toward peace, insisting instead on a comprehensive settlement, but Moscow has announced several short,

unilateral ceasefires. Zelenskyy said he doubted the Kremlin would take up his offer for the April 12 holiday pause as Russia is currently benefiting from higher oil prices driven by the Iran war.

Zelenskyy is concerned that a prolonged US-Israeli war on Iran could erode America's support for Ukraine. The US-led talks have made no progress on key issues, as Washington's attention is held by the Middle East conflict, and the Russian and Ukrainian armies remain locked in battle on the roughly 1,250-kilometre front line.

At the same time, Russia has pounded Ukraine's

capabilities," the Institute for the Study of War, a Washington-based think tank, said in an assessment late Monday.

"Russia's geographical size poses an enormous challenge to defend, especially with traditional air defence systems on which the Russians reportedly still rely to protect against Ukraine drone salvos," it added. Russia is also targeting public transport, including Ukraine's vital rail network and bus services.

On Tuesday morning, a Russian drone struck a bus as it approached a stop, killing four civilians and injuring 15 others, in the southeastern Ukraine city



power grid in an effort to demoralise civilians while Kyiv's domestically produced long-range drones have repeatedly hit Russian oil infrastructure in a bid to dent Moscow's main export revenue. "Ukraine's expanding long-range strike campaign against Russian oil infrastructure is exploiting overstretched Russian air defences and significantly damaging Russian oil export

of Nikopol, authorities said.

"This brutal attack on civilian regular transportation occurred during rush hour, when people were just going to work," Interior Minister Ihor said. "This is not an accident, it's their (Russian) tactic: deliberate strikes on civilians." Also, Ukrainian authorities said three people were killed in an attack on a residential building in Kherson. (AP)

Video brings new scrutiny of ICE shooting in US

STEVE KARNOWSKI
■ Minneapolis

The city of Minneapolis released a video showing a chase and scuffle that ended in a nonfatal shooting in January and the suspensions of two federal officers involved in the Trump administration's immigration crackdown in Minnesota.

The video — from a city-owned security camera — captured part of the incident in which federal officers chased a Venezuelan man to his residence. Another Venezuelan man who lives there was shot during the confrontation.

Federal authorities in February dropped all charges against the two immigrants and opened a criminal investigation into whether two immigration officers lied under oath about what had happened.

The city released the video after the New York Times, which obtained a copy earlier, reported that the footage raised questions about why it took weeks for the federal Government's case against the two men to collapse.

The Times reported that federal investigators had access to the video within hours of the Jan 14 shooting, but did not watch it until nearly three weeks after they had charged the two men. "The video makes it crystal clear that, just like in other situations during Operation Metro Surge, the federal Government's



account of what happened simply does not match the facts," Minneapolis Mayor Jacob Frey said in a statement. Federal authorities initially accused Alfredo Alejandro Aljorna and Julio Cesar Sosa-Celis of beating an ICE officer with a broom handle and a snow shovel during the incident.

The officer fired a single shot from his handgun, striking Sosa-Celis in his right thigh. Protesters quickly flocked to the scene and clashed with other officers, who were wearing gas masks and helmets.

The city provided no narrative on what the video depicts except to say that it was "related" to the shooting. A statement added, "The City has no additional information and will not be making further comments at this time."

The video, shot from a distance in the dark, appears to show a person standing with a snow shovel outside the house, near the street, then retreating toward the house and tossing the shovel into the yard. (AP)



Vietnam's top leader To Lam swears in as the country's president in Hanoi, Vietnam

Vietnam elects Communist Party chief as president, echoing China's power structure

ANIRUDDHA GHOSAL ■ Hanoi

Vietnam unanimously elected Communist Party General Secretary To Lam as president for a five-year term, consolidating his control over both the party and the state.

The move departs from Vietnam's tradition of shared leadership, in which the jobs have typically been held by different people, and echoes power structures in China under Xi Jinping and neighbouring Laos.

It has been widely expected since Lam's reelection as Communist Party head in January, when observers noted that his consolidation of party authority positioned him to assume the presidency as well.

After being sworn in, the 69-year-old told the National Assembly that his top priority was to maintain peace and stability, which were the foundation for fast and sustainable growth. "We aim to improve people's livelihoods so all can share the benefits of development," he said. This is To Lam's

second time holding both jobs, after briefly doing so in 2024 when his predecessor as party chief, Nguyen Phu Trong, died.

The concentration of power was significant since it meant that Lam had a "stronger mandate and far more political room to push through his agenda than any leaders" since the 1980s, when Hanoi launched reforms to shed a state-run economy in favour of a market-oriented one open to foreigners, said Nguyen Khac Giang, of Singapore's ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute research centre.

"The opportunity is obvious. Faster decision-making, greater policy coherence, and a better chance of pushing difficult reforms at a pivotal moment. But the risk is that concentration of power can move faster than institutional reform," he said.

Lam's rise to the top caps the ascent of a career policeman who advanced from Vietnam's security services to the top of the political system. (AP)

US envoy to India Sergei Gor meets JD Vance

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

US Ambassador to India Sergei Gor met Vice President JD Vance and thanked him for "continued leadership and attention" to the relationship with New Delhi.

Gor, who has been in the US for the past few days, is scheduled to meet Trump over dinner on Tuesday.

"Just wrapped a fantastic meeting with the VP. Thank you @VP Vance for your continued leadership and attention to the US-India relationship. Under President Trump's leadership, the White House is fully engaged in the region," Gor said in a social media



US Ambassador to India Sergei Gor

post on Monday.

Earlier, he also met FBI Director Kash Patel and had a "constructive discussion" on US-India cooperation to counter transnational threats – cybercrime, narcotics and illicit networks. "A constructive discussion with @FBI Director Kash on US-

India cooperation to counter transnational threats-cybercrime, narcotics, and illicit networks. Strong alignment on security priorities," Gor said in another social media post.

He complimented Patel for doing a "fantastic job" at the FBI.

India-US relationship achieved goals: Kwatra

US Vinay Mohan Kwatra met US envoy to New Delhi Sergei Gor and said both sides are pursuing robust efforts to achieve the goals set by their leaders for the strategic relationship between the two countries.

"Good to catch up with my friend, Amb Sergio Gor @USAmbIndia, during his visit to Washington DC," Kwatra said in a social media post on Monday.

"Respect and value his partnership, as we continue our robust efforts to achieve the goals agreed by our two leaders for the India-US strategic ties," he said. (PTI)

JD Vance arrives in Hungary, hoping to boost Orban's campaign

JUSTIN SPIKE
■ Budapest

US Vice President JD Vance arrived in Hungary's Capital on Tuesday in a bid to turn the tide of an election campaign where long-serving Prime Minister Viktor Orban, a close ally of President Donald Trump, is trailing in the polls.

Vance's two-day trip, where he is scheduled to hold an official visit with Orban and later appear at one of his campaign rallies, was the clearest sign yet that the Trump administration was going all-in for an Orban victory when Hungarians go to the polls on Sunday.

In power since 2010, Orban is running for his fifth-



US Vice President JD Vance speaking during a press conference in Budapest, Hungary

straight term as prime minister. He and his nationalist-populist Fidesz party are facing their toughest race in two decades against a

centre-right challenger, the Tisza party led by Peter Magyar, that could bring an end to Orban's 16 years in power. Long accused by

critics of taking over Hungary's institutions, clamping down on press freedom and overseeing entrenched political corruption - charges he denies - Orban has become an icon in the global far-right movement. Trump has repeatedly endorsed Orban's candidacy for reelection, and many in the Make America Great Again movement approve of the Hungarian leader's opposition to immigration, curtailing of LGBTQ+ rights, and capture of the media and academia.

But with most independent polls showing a double-digit deficit for Fidesz among decided voters ahead of the April 12 vote, Orban has sought to boost his profile by appearing publicly with his

international admirers.

The vice president's visit wasn't the first sign of US support for Orban.

Hungary, which has broken with most European Union countries by refusing to assist Ukraine with financial assistance or weapons to ward off Russia's full-scale invasion, has remained firmly committed to purchasing Russian energy despite EU efforts to wean off such supplies.

Late last month, Orban hosted dozens of allies from around Europe and beyond at the Hungarian iteration of the Conservative Political Action Conference, and at a meeting of the far-right Patriots for Europe party family, the third-largest group in the European Parliament. (AP)

3 killed as high winds topple tree at Easter egg hunt in Germany



DAVID MCHUGH ■ Frankfurt

Three people, including a 10-month-old girl, were killed Sunday when high winds toppled a tree in northern Germany during an Easter egg hunt, police said.

Around 50 people from a nearby residential facility for new mothers, pregnant women and children were attending the event in woods near the town of Satrupholm at about 11 am when a 30-metre tree fell on the group, police said in a statement. Four people were pinned under the tree. A 21-year-old woman and a 16-year-old girl were treated by first responders but died at the scene, while the woman's 10-month-old daughter died later in the hospital. An 18-

year-old woman suffered serious injuries and was brought to the hospital by helicopter.

The facility is part of the state-funded child welfare system and supports pregnant women and new mothers who need help, according to its website. Grief counsellors were sent to the scene. Pictures from the scene published by the Bild news site showed several Easter eggs scattered on the ground and two of the victims covered in white sheets. The area had been under a high-winds warning from the German weather service.

Government officials from the Schleswig-Holstein region, where the facility was located, said they were "deeply shaken" by the accident. (AP)

30 Indian fishermen repatriated from Sri Lanka return home



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Thirty Indian fishermen were repatriated from Sri Lanka on Tuesday and are currently on their way back home, authorities said.

"30 Indian fishermen were repatriated from Sri Lanka today and are on their way home," the Indian High Commission here said in a post on X. The fishermen issue is a contentious one in the ties between India and Sri

Lanka, with Lankan Navy personnel even firing at Indian fishermen in the Palk Strait and seizing their boats in several alleged incidents of illegally entering Sri Lankan territorial waters. The Palk Strait, a narrow strip of water separating Tamil Nadu from Sri Lanka, is a rich fishing ground for fishermen from both countries. Fishermen from both countries are arrested frequently for inadvertently trespassing into each other's waters.

Two women leaders in fray to become next Secretary General in UN



YOSHITA SINGH
■ United Nations

Two women leaders are in the fray to become the next Secretary General of the UN, nominated along with two male candidates, amid a growing call for the first female to be elected as head of the global organisation in its 80-year-old history.

The process to elect the next Secretary General of the United Nations gets underway this month with the four nominated candidates for the post participating in interactive dialogues scheduled to be held at the UN Headquarters on April 21 and 22. UN chief Antonio Guterres, the former Prime Minister of Portugal and former United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, will complete his second five-year term as head of the global organisation in December 2026.

He had assumed office in 2017 as the ninth Secretary General of the UN, an organisation that has never seen a female leader at its helm in 80 years of its existence. (PTI)

Bangladesh conducts emergency measles vaccinations as outbreak kills 100 children

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dhaka

Bangladesh is conducting emergency measles-rubella vaccinations while trying to contain an ongoing outbreak that has killed more than 100 children in less than a month.

The Government, in partnership with the World Health Organisation, the UN children's agency and the Gavi vaccine alliance, began working to vaccinate children aged 6 months to 5 years old in 18 high-risk districts on Sunday and will expand nationwide in phases from next month, a joint statement said.

A UNICEF official said the agency was deeply con-



A nurse treating a child suffering from measles at the Infectious Diseases Hospital in Dhaka, Bangladesh

cerned about the sharp rise in cases, which was putting the youngest and most vulnerable children at serious risk.

"This resurgence high-

lights critical immunity gaps, particularly among zero-dose and under-vaccinated children, while infections among infants under nine months, who are not yet eli-

gible for routine vaccination, are especially alarming," said Rana Flowers, the agency's representative in Bangladesh. More than 900 cases of measles have been confirmed among 7,500 suspected cases reported since March 15, according to the official data in the South Asian nation of more than 170 million people.

Measles is a highly contagious airborne disease causing fever, respiratory symptoms and a characteristic rash and can sometimes have severe or fatal complications, especially in young children, according to WHO. Vaccination is crucial to preventing the spread of measles, but the

WHO says 95 per cent of the population has to be vaccinated in order to stop the disease from spreading.

Bangladesh's Health Minister Sardar Mohammed Sakhawat Husain, responding to questions in Parliament, said Monday that the new outbreak was caused by the mismanagement and failures of past Governments.

He said the previous Government of ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina and an interim Government headed by Nobel Peace Prize laureate Muhammad Yunus failed to make proper decisions regarding vaccine stockpiles, causing shortages affecting

vaccines for measles and six other diseases.

The vaccination campaign for measles was disrupted during Bangladesh's recent political upheavals. Hasina was ousted in a mass uprising in 2024, and Yunus led an interim administration that transferred power to an elected Government after an election in February.

Authorities are advising parents to go to hospitals whenever someone is suspected of having measles.

"They should avoid taking medicine from shopkeepers unnecessarily. If a child has a fever, especially a high fever - 101, 102, 3, 4 (Fahrenheit, or higher than 38.3 Celsius) - they should not

PROSPECT

From 58 to 72 years: ICICI Pru GPP Flexi tackles retirement challenges

Good news from the UNDP's 2025 Human Development Report: India's average life expectancy climbed to 72 years in 2023 from 58.6 in 1990. Interestingly, a Government data on 'Elderly in India' suggests that by 2036 nearly one in seven Indians will be aged 60 years or older. While these projections are good signs of the improving healthcare in India, an individual must be cognisant about the challenges posed by the rising life expectancy as well. Understanding this challenge and to make retirement planning easy, ICICI Prudential Life has designed ICICI Pru Guaranteed Pension Plan Flexi which enables customers to effectively plan their retirement.

According to a statement, the rate of interest at which the regular income will be paid out is fixed at the time of purchasing the product, this means the guaranteed regular income does not fluctuate with interest rate movements.

Commenting on the plan, Vikas Gupta, Chief Product Officer of ICICI Prudential Life Insurance, said, "Retirement planning is driven by one core need – certainty of income for life. ICICI Pru Guaranteed Pension Plan Flexi is designed to deliver this certainty through a simple and flexible structure. In fact, it offers 7 flexible options to customers to serve their different needs.



Govt may seek revised financial bids from 2 potential buyers for IDBI Bank

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government may ask for revised financial bids from two potential buyers of IDBI Bank as their original bid amounts were lower than the reserve price fixed for the strategic sale of the lender, sources said.

"The IDBI Bank strategic sale is in the technical evaluation stage," a senior official told PTI.

Amidst the West Asia crisis, the Government is banking on disinvestment and asset monetisation to garner resources and create fiscal space for measures to shield the economy from the global uncertainty, officials said.

After over three years of pursuit, the strategic sale of IDBI Bank had reached the final stage of financial bid, and the Government does not want to restart the process again to avoid further delay. The Government and LIC were together looking to sell 60.72 per cent in IDBI



Bank and had floated an Expression of Interest (Eoi) in October 2022. Financial bids came on February 6.

After that, the Government set the reserve price for the strategic sale. The financial bids for the IDBI Bank strategic sale, however, came in lower than the reserve price set by the inter-ministerial group on disinvestment headed by secretaries in the finance ministry.

Following that, the strate-

gic sale of IDBI Bank hit a roadblock.

Sources said that the Government has now restarted work to take forward the IDBI Bank strategic sale to a logical conclusion.

Prem Watsa-led Fairfax and Emirates NBD are reported to have put in bids for the strategic sale of IDBI Bank.

Currently, the Government and state-owned LIC together hold a 94.71 per cent stake in IDBI Bank. The Government owns 45.48 per cent, and LIC holds 49.24 per cent in the lender. Of this, the Government and LIC are looking to sell 60.72 per cent in IDBI Bank.

In October 2022, the Government and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) had invited Expression of Interest (Eoi) for selling 60.72 per cent stake in IDBI Bank. The Centre and LIC look to pare 30.48 and 30.24 per cent stake, respectively.

In January 2023, the Government said it received multiple preliminary bids. Following that, the bids were sent for security clearance from the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) and for the 'Fit and Proper' assessment from the RBI.

The shortlisted bidders who received both the clearances later on undertook due diligence of the bank, and the Government, in January, invited financial bids. In February, the Government announced that it received financial bids for IDBI Bank.

Kharat sexually exploited women with divine power and death threat, says SIT



Ashok Kharat (middle) in Police custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Self-styled godman-cum-astrologer Ashok Kharat allegedly sexually exploited women by claiming that he possessed "divine power" and would use it to cause the death of their family members or defame them if they didn't comply, according to investigators. He used the same modus operandi, conducted "rituals" and also used items like stones and tamarind seeds for intimidation and "divine invocation".

Kharat, currently in police custody, is facing 12 criminal cases in Ahilya Nagar and Nashik city, including eight for sexual assault. The SIT has recorded statements of 30 witnesses and victims so far, said IPS officer Tejaswi Satpute, who heads the SIT, on Tuesday.

"During questioning, it came to light that the accused exploited the faith of victims and their families. By instilling fear of death in the victim's family members and using items like stones, tamarind seeds, and conducting rituals, he extorted money from them," Satpute told reporters.

She added that the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has launched a probe into financial transactions allegedly linked to Kharat and his properties.

Indian Army organises medical camp on World Health Day at Pengree

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

On the occasion of World Health Day, the Red Shield Gunners of the Indian Army, under the aegis of Spear Corps, organised a comprehensive Medical Camp at Pengree, Tinsukia, in coordination with the Red Cross Society, AANS and Pengree Tea Estate.



The initiative aimed at promoting health awareness and providing essential medical support to the local community.

The camp witnessed wide public participation and included health check-ups, diagnostic services including cancer screening, and awareness sessions on preventive healthcare.

Special focus was laid on women and child health, with distribution of sanitary

pads, newborn care kits for new mothers and essential medicines for pregnant women.

The initiative served as a meaningful outreach effort, reinforcing the importance of accessible healthcare and community wellbeing. The active involvement of multiple stakeholders ensured

effective delivery of medical services and awareness at the grassroots level.

The programme reaffirmed the Indian Army's continued commitment towards community welfare, health awareness and service to the nation, strengthening bonds with local communities.

ALEMAI seeks policy support amid aluminium industry slowdown

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Aluminium Extrusion Manufacturers Association of India (ALEMAI) launched the 'Aluminium Bharat' initiative in New Delhi, unveiled by Minister of State Jitin Prasada, to strengthen India's aluminium ecosystem. It aims to unite policymakers and industry leaders to address challenges and drive sustainable growth.

As part of this, 'Aluminium Bharat 2026', a comprehensive exhibition, will be held in Gandhinagar alongside Alumex India.

Addressing the gathering, Prasada underscored the need to build resilient domestic manufacturing capabilities in the face of evolving global trade dynamics. "The initiative, 'Aluminium Bharat', is a

statement of intent that India will move up the global value chain in aluminium manufacturing. We are committed to giving Indian manufacturers a level playing field and making Bharat a preferred global hub for high-value aluminium products," said Prasada.

The industry faces a 40-50 per cent production decline,



high energy and raw material costs, and rising imports due to global disruptions and tariff imbalances.

ALEMAI has called for reliable energy access and policy support. The sector, supporting over 10 lakh jobs, remains vital for value addition, self-reliance, and India's broader economic and sustainability goals.

DAILY SUDOKU

				9	3			4
			2				6	8
1	9		8					
		3	4			6		
	6	9				3	4	
		1			7	8		
					2		3	7
3	8				1			
5			3	6				

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



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SOLUTION (07.04.26)								
2	7	3	9	5	6	1	8	4
8	4	6	3	7	1	9	2	5
5	1	9	8	2	4	6	3	7
6	8	7	2	4	9	5	1	3
9	5	2	1	3	8	7	4	6
4	3	1	5	6	7	2	9	8
1	6	8	7	9	3	4	5	2
7	9	5	4	8	2	3	6	1
3	2	4	6	1	5	8	7	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | APRIL 8, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9			10		
11		12				
13			14		15	16
		18		19		
20		21			23	
22			24		25	
26	27	28		29		30
31				32		33
						35
36						37
			38			

SOLUTION (07.04.26)					
ACROSS			DOWN		
1, Clash	19, Widen	2, Laws-on	15, Top-A-Z		
6, Verse	20, The lot	3, S-well-5	16, Yemen		
9, Wave-red	24, Her	4, Hat	18, Merit (remit)		
10, S-wee-t	25, Citi-Z-en	5, Fetes	19, Works up		
11, Reins	26, Skirt	6, Verge on	21, Header		
12, Reign	27, Adit-os	7, E-den	22, Tisane		
13, Loll-I-e-s	28, Da-LL-y	8, S-a-NT-OS	23, Med-lar		
15, To-y	29, Surge-on	12, R-emit	25, Cra-G-s		
17, Ones	30, Dr-O-op	13, Lout-h	26, So-G-o		
18, Moros-E	31, Terry	14, Lever	28, Dot		

- ACROSS
- 3 Condescend in too hearty a manner? (5)
- 8 Group of bewitching females (5)
- 10 South African part of the Atlantic, possibly (5)
- 11 One stuck quietly in? (3)
- 12 Mother, it seems, is a winner at chess (5)
- 13 Allowed Edgar to shuffle out of the theatre (7)
- 15 Figure how to cultivate the allotment (5)
- 18 Some nuclear material, as a weapon (3)
- 19 This way, it's simple to take in a faint-hearted novice (6)

- DOWN
- 1 Nutty product of policeman and artist (5)
- 2 Flag of the state founder, a six-footer (7)
- 4 It's more appetising when in the hole (4)
- 5 Only 24 hours, but it's in the vague future (3,3)
- 6 Where the standard remains capital (5)
- 7 He's a matter of taste (5)
- 9 The Roman way (3)
- 12 At the club, are they all arms and legs? (7)
- 14 A shot from the sentry (3)
- 16 One yielding to a generous impulse? (5)

- 21 An individual who's not particular (7)
- 22 Nasty turn for a little one! (4)
- 23 An inherited name? (4)
- 24 Tender in the manner of "16 Down" (7)
- 26 Summary or note in crisp style (6)
- 29 Paisley, perhaps? (3)
- 31 Here's a meaty word for the boys (5)
- 32 Historic period, as a rule (7)
- 34 Eager to weave braid (5)
- 35 Deserter from a concentration camp (3)
- 36 Plaintive cry when the table breaks (5)
- 37 The churchman's official list (5)
- 38 May need stopping before they get too bad (5)

- 17 They're of pretty resilient material (5)
- 19 Elevatingly educated (7)
- 20 Diagram sometimes accompanied by a photo (5)
- 21 Spirit needed to be a nurse (5)
- 23 He gives orders all over the place (7)
- 24 Dish out a portion of pie for the governor (6)
- 25 The boy smoked to the very end! (3)
- 27 Morally deficient, we gather (5)
- 28 Weight of a cart? (5)
- 30 Do a bit more somewhere in London (5)
- 32 A crack that can lead to much strife (4)
- 33 A girl's name for bread (3)

IRFC opens financial year with ₹1,000 crore disbursement to MAHAGENCO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Continuing its role in augmenting the country's core infrastructure, Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC), a Navratna CPSE under the Ministry of Railways, on Monday announced that it has sanctioned and fully disbursed a ₹1,000 crore term loan to Maharashtra State Power Generation Company Limited (MAHAGENCO). The development comes close on the heels of its recent ₹12,842 crore loan agreement with Hindustan Urvarak & Rasayan Limited.

"A wonderful start to the new financial year. Our first disbursement going to a trusted business partner is not just a



transaction, it is a statement of confidence, continuity, and commitment," the Chairman and Managing Director of IRFC, Manoj Kumar Dubey said, adding, "I congratulate the team for this early achievement and encourage everyone to sustain this momentum." Established in 1986 as the

dedicated financing arm of the Ministry of Railways, IRFC has played a key role in mobilising long-term resources for India's rail infrastructure at competitive rates. In recent years, the company has expanded its footprint as a diversified infrastructure financier, with a mandate extending to sectors linked to the railway ecosystem, including power generation, transmission, mining, fuel and coal, logistics, and urban transport.

The CMD added that IRFC will continue to deepen its engagement across infrastructure sectors while maintaining financial discipline. "Together, we will ensure that this year is defined by strong partnerships and outstanding performance, while staying aligned with our core mandate," he noted.

Indian Army at Sigar Military Station honours Civil–Military Synergy in wildfire response

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

Spearhead Division of Spearcorps organised a felicitation ceremony at Sigar on 06 April 2026 to honour the exemplary efforts of the Civil Administration, State Police, Fire & Emergency Services, SDRF personnel, people's representatives and local villagers in successfully combating the recent wildfire that engulfed Sigar and adjoining areas. The wildfire, which posed a significant threat to both civilian habitations and critical defence infrastructure was effectively contained through seamless coordination and swift joint action by military and civil agencies.

The operation witnessed the deployment of Quick Reaction Teams (QRTs), water bowsters and aerial firefighting efforts by the Indian Air Force, demonstrating a high degree of operational synergy.

The ceremony was graced by Hon'ble MLA Shri Oken Tayeng, along with the



Deputy Commissioner and Superintendent of Police of East Siang district, senior officials from the Fire Department, SDRF, Police and other civil agencies. Local villagers and volunteers, whose timely support and resilience were instrumental in controlling the blaze, were also present and felicitated.

Speaking on the occasion, senior military officials lauded the unwavering commitment, courage and spirit of cooperation displayed by all stakeholders. The collective response

not only ensured the swift containment of the fire but also safeguarded lives, property and vital installations.

The event underscored the importance of civil–military fusion in disaster response and highlighted how integrated efforts can set new benchmarks in crisis management.

The success of the operation stands as a testament to unity in action and reinforces the enduring bond between the Armed Forces and the civil populace.

BRIEFLY

Own goal gives Girona win over Villarreal in La Liga



Villarreal fell at Girona 1-0 and missed a chance to cement its third-place position in La Liga. With fourth-placed Atletico Madrid losing at home to Barcelona, a win for Villarreal on Monday would have taken it four points clear. However, Arnau's cross hit Pau Navarro and deflected past his own goalkeeper in first-half stoppage time. It was the only shot on target for either side during a dour opening 45 minutes and neither side was much better in a poor second half. Villarreal remained in third spot, nine points behind Real Madrid and 18 adrift of leader Barcelona. Girona climbed two places into 12th, one point behind Osasuna, Espanyol and Athletic Bilbao.

Agyemang's World Cup hopes clouded after stretcher exit



US striker Patrick Agyemang's World Cup hopes were in doubt after he was carried off on a stretcher while playing for Derby in the English second-tier. Agyemang landed awkwardly while bringing the ball down on his chest and collapsed to the grass on Monday. He was visibly emotional as he was taken off, his right leg strapped. "He's gone for a scan so we'll just have to wait and see," Derby manager John Eustace said. "It's not good when a player comes off on a stretcher." In his absence, Derby beat Stoke City 2-0. Agyemang has helped Derby rise into contention for promotion from the Championship thanks to a team-leading 10 goals since arriving last summer from Charlotte in Major League Soccer. During the recent international break, he came off the bench for the United States and scored in a loss against Belgium and got minutes against Portugal.

Fan dies after cardiac arrest at German Bundesliga soccer game

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Frankfurt

A long-time Eintracht Frankfurt supporter died in hospital, aged 87, hours after suffering a cardiac arrest in the stadium during a German Bundesliga game, the club said on Tuesday.

The stadium fell silent as paramedics worked to revive the man, who hasn't been named, during the second half of Frankfurt's 2-2 draw with Cologne on Sunday. "The 87-year-old, who was a long-standing member of



the club and had held a season ticket for many years, suffered a cardiac arrest during the match. Although

he was successfully resuscitated at the scene, his condition could not be stabilised," Frankfurt said.

Arteta wants Arsenal players to turn pain of losses into gain

ANNIE MA ■ Lisbon

After Arsenal's first consecutive losses this season — taking trophies out of play — coach Mikel Arteta wants his players to turn the pain of their last two results into gain.

Arteta has been drumming into his players to embrace their defeats in the FA Cup quarterfinals and English League Cup final and remember they're still contending in the Premier League and Champions League.

Their immediate focus was the Champions League quarterfinal first leg at Sporting Lisbon on Tuesday, and fighting off outside noise about yet another late-season swoon.

"What you have to be is clear," he said on Monday.

"Instead of panically understand if that happens why it happened, and bring clarity. And when you analyse that

and you accept that you will be better. That's it, and that's the thing that we have to do.

"Have some perspective on how difficult it is. Feel that pain, feel that emotion, and use it to be better and to improve. There are a few things that we have discussed internally, and I'm very convinced that tomorrow we're going to see that.

"I know what it means to them and I know how much they want it. Now is the moment to show it, and we have to do it tomorrow at the highest level. We are hungrier than ever, very excited and very, very motivated."

Arteta welcomed good news regarding the availability of defender Gabriel Magalhaes, midfielder Declan Rice and forward Leandro Trossard for the match against Sporting.

They were among 10 Arsenal



players who missed games for their national team over the international break because of various issues.

Arteta also said Bukayo Saka and

be a creature of habit, and wants to eat what they're comfortable with and go," Reed said after a practice round on Monday, "but I like checking out all the local places and really experiencing the culture."

Pimento cheese sandwich, anyone? The truth is as much as Reed enjoyed playing in Dubai and Qatar, where he packed wins around a playoff loss in Bahrain — 1,200 miles (7,500 km) from home, wife Justine and their two kids — there are few things Reed loves more than walking among the Georgia pines.

It's not exactly home; that's The Woodlands, Texas. But it sure feels like it.

Reed played college golf down the road at Georgia, and he recalls practice rounds spent at Augusta Country Club, where certain



holes offer a teasing glimpse through the trees of the par-5 13th hole of its much more famous neighbour.

"There's just something so special about this place, the traditions behind it, and

then on top of it, it's the one major that stays in the same place," Reed said.

"All the way back from when I played my first time ever here, even when we played in November that

Maguire signs contract extension at Man United

JAMES ROBSON
■ Manchester (England)

Harry Maguire signed a one-year contract extension at Manchester United on Tuesday, with the option of a further 12 months.

The England defender was due to be out of contract at the end of the season.

"Harry represents the mentality and resilience required to perform for Manchester United. He is the ultimate professional who brings invaluable experience and leadership to our young, ambitious squad," director of football Jason Wilcox said.

Maguire joined United from Leicester in 2019 for \$97 million, which was a world-record transfer for a defender. He has won

the FA Cup and League Cup with the club and has made 266 appearances.

The 33-year-old center-back looked set to leave in 2023 after losing his position under former manager Erik ten Hag. He has since established himself as a key figure and has earned a recall to the England squad ahead of the World Cup.

"Representing Manchester United is the ultimate honour. It is a responsibility that makes myself and my family proud every single day," he said. "I am delighted to extend my journey at this incredible club to at least eight seasons and continue to play in front of our special supporters to create more amazing moments together." (AP)



Rodriguez returns to MLS club in Minnesota

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Golden Valley (US)

Colombian star James Rodriguez, who was hospitalised last week for severe dehydration, returned to his MLS club Minnesota United to continue his ramp-up to game readiness.

The team announced that Rodriguez reported to the practice facility for a supervised return-to-activity session on Monday. His reintegration into full team training will be fully guided by the club's medical staff.

Rodriguez played for Colombia's national team in an exhibition match against France on March 29, when his symptoms of dehydration began. He was hospitalised two days later for continued monitoring and IV fluid therapy. Since his discharge after a three-day



hospital stay, Rodriguez has been recovering at home with continued medical supervision, the team said. Minnesota United said its medical staff "can unequivocally state there has been

no clinical or laboratory evidence of rhabdomyolysis," referring to a rare but life-threatening condition in which muscles can disintegrate from overexertion or other causes.

The Colombian Football Federation issued a statement last week declaring a favorable prognosis for Rodriguez's recovery and improvement. Colombia's first World Cup match is on June 17 against Uzbekistan.

Rodriguez became a worldwide star at the 2014 World Cup, when he won the Golden Boot award as the tournament's leading scorer with six goals in five matches. He joined Real Madrid in Spain after that, spending six seasons with the La Liga powerhouse and also had stays with Bayern Munich in Germany's Bundesliga and Everton in the English Premier League.

Since signing with Minnesota United two months ago, Rodriguez has played in just two of six matches with the club.

one (COVID) year, and any time I've come back and played it, it's always in perfect shape. It's one of those golf courses that you can't hit just one golf shot. You have to play golf kind of old-school way. You have to hit shots, different shapes, different flights."

Indeed, the Masters has been one of the few constants on Reed's ever-changing global calendar. When he resigned from the PGA Tour, Reed effectively said farewell to familiar, high-profile places like Pebble Beach and Bay Hill for LIV events in far-flung corners of the world. But his status as a former Masters champion meant that, despite the deep rift that once appeared to threaten the game itself, Reed was always welcomed back to Augusta National.

He tied for fourth a few years ago. He was third last year.

"I feel like it's the best test of golf we play all year round," Reed said.

"For a guy that's played just about everywhere in the world - just about - it's one of those places that I say, hands down, it's the best test of golf and best golf course I've ever played."

Reed acknowledged Monday that LIV had presented him with a contract earlier this year to remain one of its biggest stars. But when he talked with his family, "I felt like the best decision for us was to come back and join the PGA Tour."

Even when he left, Reed said, he always considered the PGA Tour to be the best barometer of golf greatness.

Tiger Woods topic of conversation at Masters without being there

DOUG FERGUSON
■ Augusta (US)

Tiger Woods was a big part of the conversation on Monday at the Masters without even being at Augusta National. His absence stemming from his arrest on suspicion of driving under the influence brought a degree of criticism from Jason Day.

Florida authorities determined Woods was impaired March 27 when his Land Rover struck a trailer and flipped on its side on a residential street. They found two painkiller pills in his pocket. Woods was arrested and briefly jailed for refusing to submit to a urine test. "He's just a human being like everyone else and we have struggles," Day said. "It's unfortunate. The only thing that I don't understand is that it's a little bit selfish of him to drive and put other people in harm's way, as well."

"But when you're the player that he was and how strong-willed he is, he thinks he can do almost anything," Day said. "And that's probably why he's driving and a little bit under the influence."

This is the second straight year Woods has missed the Masters, under entirely different circumstances. He had ruptured his Achilles tendon in March of 2025 and didn't even make it to the Masters Club dinner for champions. Woods entered a plea of not guilty last week, and then sought — and was granted — a motion to seek treatment outside the country.

"He was my hero — he's my hero," said Day, the Australian who reached No 1 in the world a decade ago.

"The reason why I play golf is because of this tournament and Tiger. It's hard to see him go through what he's going through, and especially under the microscope. It must be hard to be who he is and have everything, everyone look on, kind of down on him. "Some people want him to fail. Some people obviously want him to succeed," Day said. "

"It's really difficult for me to go through that and watch him, and I know that he's getting the help now, which is good. I'm just hoping he comes out on the other side and is better." (AP)



Matteo Politano late goal lifts Napoli into second in Serie A

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Turin (Italy)

Substitute Matteo Politano scored late to give Napoli a 1-0 win over fellow title chaser AC Milan and close the gap on Serie A leader Inter Milan.

With Napoli starting the night in third place, one point behind AC Milan and 10 behind Inter, both clubs knew a win on Monday was needed to keep alive their title aspirations.

However, neither showed much urgency or guile in a game that featured few clear scoring chances.

Politano, who replaced



Leonardo Spinazzola just five minutes earlier, eventually broke the deadlock with 11 minutes remaining when he fired home a low shot after the Milan defense failed to

clear a cross from the left.

Milan poured forward in the final minutes but could not get an equalizer and dropped to third.

Napoli was seven points

behind Inter with seven matches remaining. AC Milan was two points further back. **McKennie stars for Juve:** US midfielder Weston McKennie scored for Juventus to beat Genoa 2-0 and was named man of the match.

McKennie netted 17 minutes after kickoff to add to a fourth minute opener from Brazilian defender Bremer.

McKennie missed two chances to add to his tally and the woodwork also came to Genoa's rescue when Jonathan David hit the post. Genoa defender Aaron Martin missed a golden opportunity to bring the

visitor back into the game with 15 minutes remaining when Mattia Perin got down brilliantly to save his penalty kick and his rebound.

The result enabled Juventus to close the gap on fourth-placed Como to one point. Como was held by Udinese to 0-0.

Cesc Fabregas' men were on top for most of the game but could not find a way past Maduka Okoye in the Udinese goal.

The result brought Como's five-game winning streak to an end in Serie A but the point kept alive its hope of winning a Champions League place.

Bayern looking to end poor run against Real Madrid

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Real Madrid and Bayern Munich are back at it in the Champions League, meeting in the quarterfinals on Tuesday for their sixth knockout-stage meeting in 14 seasons.

Bayern is looking to turn its fortunes around against Madrid after the Spanish powerhouse won four of their five two-leg matchups since the 2011-12 season.

It happened once in the quarterfinals and three times in the semifinals, most recently in 2024. Bayern won in the 2012



semifinals after a penalty shootout. Bayern striker Harry Kane missed the team's Bundesliga match

last weekend but is expected to be available for the game at the Santiago Bernabeu stadium after he trained with the squad on Monday. Coach Vincent Kompany said he will wait until closer to the game to decide on whether to use the England captain.

Bayern eliminated Atalanta in the last 16, while Madrid got past Manchester City. Bayern is unbeaten in its last 13 games in all competitions, with 11 wins, while Madrid is coming off a 2-1 loss at Mallorca on Saturday that hurt its La Liga title hopes.

Jaiswal, Sooryavanshi fireworks sink MI in rain-hit clash

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Guwahati

Rajasthan Royals inflicted on Mumbai Indians a crushing 27-run defeat in their rain-curtailed IPL match here on Tuesday.

Having posted a formidable 150 for three in the game that was reduced to 11-overs-a-side contest following a rain delay, RR bowlers stopped MI at 123 for nine in their full quota of overs.

Asked to bat first, openers Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi went all guns blazing from the get-go, putting on 80 runs in only 5 overs at the Barsapara Stadium.

Jaiswal top-scored with an unbeaten 77 off 32 balls, while the 15-year-old Sooryavanshi plundered 39 runs in just 14 deliveries, including whacking the great Jasprit Bumrah for two sixes in his very first over.

Earlier in the evening,

Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi unleashed a blistering display of power-hitting to propel Rajasthan Royals to 150 for 3 in their rain-curtailed IPL match here on Tuesday.

Jaiswal (77 not out off 32 balls) and Sooryavanshi (39 off 14) hit a flurry of boundaries, including nine sixes combined, in an opening partnership of 80 runs in just five overs.

Jaiswal anchored the innings with authority, blending elegance with brute force as he struck 10 fours and four sixes in his knock, dictating terms from the outset.

With the contest reduced to 11 overs a side, Jaiswal came out with clear intent, dismantling Deepak Chahar in the very first over to collect 22 runs with a series of audacious strokes, which included a crisp four through midwicket, a towering six, and three more boundaries that set the



TEEN SENSATION SOORYAVANSHI MATCHED HIS SENIOR PARTNER STROKE FOR STROKE, SHOWING REMARKABLE COMPOSURE

tone for the onslaught.

Teen sensation Sooryavanshi matched his senior partner stroke for stroke, showing remarkable composure as he took on Jasprit Bumrah (0/32 in 3 overs), dispatching him for a six before following it up with another towering hit over deep square leg.

Jaiswal welcomed Trent Boult (0/22 in 1) by dispatching him for three sixes, as the duo made full use of the power-play, racing to 59 in just 3.2 overs in a start that resembled a highlight reel.

While Hardik Pandya (0/17

in 2) managed to slip in a tidy four-run over, the Royals' openers continued to punish anything loose from the MI pacers.

Shardul Thakur bore the brunt next, conceding two sixes and a four to the rampaging Sooryavanshi before having the last laugh, with Tilak Varma pulling off a sharp catch at deep extra cover to end the youngster's explosive cameo.

Mumbai Indians clawed back briefly through Allah Ghazanfar (2/21), who trapped Dhruv Jurel (2) leg-before and later had Riyan Parag (20) caught at long-on.

But Jaiswal remained unfazed, continuing to dominate the bowling effortlessly. He brought up a scintillating half-century off just 23 balls with a stylish cut through point. He ended the innings with another hit to the boundary to take the Royals to the 150-run mark.

Prince of Najafgarh skips Delhi Police exam to chase IPL dream

KUSHAN SARKAR

■ New Delhi

A few years back, Najafgarh-based Railway Protection Force's ASI Ram Niwas Yadav was extremely worried about the future of his youngest son Prince Yadav, who was only interested in bowling yorkers at tennis ball tournaments.

However, the youngster was unruffled and told his father straight up, "Papa aap mera chinta karna chhod dijiye. Main apne se kuch kar loonga" (Dad stop worrying about me. I would manage something on my own)."

Cut to 2026 and the seemingly nonchalant boy has managed to come good on the promise. The Lucknow Super Giants swing sensation has already breached the defences of experienced India internationals such as Axar Patel and Ishan Kishan in successive IPL games.

"Any father would be worried about the future of his kids and so was I. Till the age of 18, he had not even bowled once with the leather ball. I literally forced him to appear for the Delhi Police's Constables' Exam and he was fit enough to clear the physical round. "But he wasn't well prepared for written test because his mind was elsewhere," recalled Ram Niwas.

But like most doting fathers, he too had no other option but to back his audacious boy.

"Bete ki zid hai aur humein pura karna tha. Ek ASI ke salary mein aur kitna hi ho pata hai (It was his passion so I had to believe in him. (But) how much can you manage with an ASI's salary?). But I am happy that I allowed him to fly on his own," said Ram Niwas, who now has people from nearby Kheda Dabar village in Najafgarh's Dariyapur thronging his house thanks to Prince's IPL exploits.

"After Ishan Kishan's dismissal (LSG vs SRH game), a lot of our neighbours came and told me that 'Usne iss dehat (rural area) ka naam roushan kar diya' (People have come up to tell me that he has brought fame to this hamlet).

"Pahle humare is ilaake ko log isliye jaante the kyonki poorv president sahibaa (Pratibha Patil) aaye the Chaudhary Bramprakash Ayurvedic Sansthan ke udgathan pe (2012). Ab cricket ke liye famous ho gaya (earlier people knew us because of a visit by former President Pratibha Patil. Now it is famous for cricket)," the pride in Ram Niwas' voice was unmissable. According to Ram Niwas, Prince's first and only coach till date, Amit Vashistha and former India U-19 World Cup winning pacer Pradeep Sangwan, played the biggest role in



shaping Prince. "I can't thank Amit sir enough. He saw him playing a tennis ball tournament and asked Prince to join his academy in Najafgarh. Pradeep ji (Sangwan) was also Amit sir's student and he helped him with fitness," he said. There was a time when Prince would tie a sand bag on his back and run through paddy fields to improve his upper body fitness.

"Pradeep guided him a lot and Amit sir taught him technique. And how can I forget DPL (Delhi Premier League) and New Delhi team. Had DPL not been there, I don't think my son's progress would have been this quick. So I am grateful to DDCA too and also Vijay Dahiya sir," said Ram Niwas. When PTI contacted the reticent Vashistha, who has been running the Sporting Cricket Club of Najafgarh for years, he spoke about Prince's inherent skill and ability to work hard.

"He could bowl yorkers and even swing the tennis ball at a decent clip. When I saw him, I told his friends to tell him to contact me. He was already 18 back then and there was very little time to quickly make the grade unlike those who come to me at 13 or 14.

"One thing that helped was his basics were strong and also he could impart back-spin on the ball, he had good arm swing — traits essential for swing bowling," said Vashistha, who has also coached the likes of Lalit Yadav (Delhi all-rounder), and Railways' Himanshu Sangwan (last man to dismiss Virat Kohli in First-Class cricket) to name a few. Vashistha feels the Prince's ability to work hard helps him stand out.

"Aap Delhi ki garmi mein 2 ghanta bowling dalwalo usse. Thakega nahi and will always follow instructions. His fitness has improved after working with Pradeep and obviously now when you get modern amenities while playing Ranji Trophy or for LSG, you can only improve. He worked with Zaheer Khan sir and now with Bharat Arun sir. Sky is the limit," said the coach.

In fact, national selectors wanted Prince to play one T20 World Cup warm-up game for India A but a knee injury left him unavailable. This was after a brilliant Vijay Hazare Trophy for Delhi where he had 18 wickets in 8 games including three-wicket hauls in four of the games. (PTI)





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